

MY CORNER OF THE WORLD

Anastasiya's Echo

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Katya's Notebook

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A work of fiction. See “A Note on the Story” at the back of the book for what is invented and what is real.

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A Note to the Reader



This novel looks at war through the eyes of a teenage girl. It deals with the death of a parent, an emergency birth, a family torn apart, and civilians forced from their homes. The violence is never graphic, but some scenes may be hard to read. It is meant for readers thirteen and up.

The story takes place in northeast Ukraine during the 2024 to 2025 school year, during Russia's full-scale invasion, which began in February 2022. Lypove, the other places, the characters, and the news outlet Passerelle Monde are all made up.

PART ONE

The Silent Bell



September to December 2024

Chapters 1–6

CHAPTER ONE

The Schoolbag That Was No Use

September 2



SOUND LOST

the eight o'clock bell.

On the first day of school, I put on my uniform even though nobody knew if the school would open.

I ironed my white blouse myself on the kitchen table. The iron didn't heat well anymore and spat out water the color of rust, but I kept at the sleeves until every crease was gone. Mama watched me from the doorway, one hand under her round belly.

"Katya, you heard what the principal said yesterday."

"She said to wait for instructions. I'll wait in front of the gate."

She could have gotten angry. Before, she used to get angry over a bowl left in the sink or a math grade that dropped below ten out of twelve. That morning she just put

three slices of bread on the table. One for her, two for me. Ever since she got pregnant, she claimed she was never hungry, and then she watched every bite I took, as if she could reach across the table and feed the baby.

I slid three new notebooks into my schoolbag. Blue for math, green for history, red for Ukrainian. They smelled of paper and glue, a clean smell, almost arrogant. They didn't know yet that you could buy them and never get to use them.

On the stairs, Baba Vira was coming up with a bucket of water. She was sixty-six, with forearms stronger than most of the men in our building and a way of saying hello that felt like an ID check.

"Where are you going, dressed up like a class photo?"

"To school."

"Then tell it to hurry up. My bucket is heavy."

Her grandson Ihor was two steps below her with a screwdriver between his teeth. He had been fixing the radio on the second floor for three days. According to him, it needed a part he couldn't find. According to Vira, what it mostly needed was for him to stop taking it apart.

Ihor took the screwdriver out of his mouth.

"If the bell rings, record it for me. I've forgotten what a miracle sounds like."

"A miracle sounds like somebody finally finishing a repair."

Vira let out a satisfied little noise. Ihor stuck his tongue out at me. For one second, we were three ordinary people on a staircase that smelled of cabbage, dust, and cheap soap.

Outside, the streets had changed over the summer. Not renovated. Changed, like a sentence corrected so roughly you can't recognize it anymore. Metal barriers blocked the avenue. Sandbags protected the pharmacy. Tape made crooked stars on the windows.

I walked fast. My schoolbag bounced against my back. I knew the distance by heart: one hundred twenty-three steps to the bus stop, thirty-seven to the two poplars, nine seconds to cross the little square if the light was green. The light didn't work anymore, but I waited beside it out of habit.

Our school stood behind a blue fence. Two classmates, Alina and Denys, were already waiting with their parents. Alina was wearing her uniform too. We looked at each other without smiling, each of us relieved not to be the only idiot.

At seven fifty-nine, the gate stayed shut.

At eight o'clock, the bell didn't ring.

Nobody left right away. It was as if we were still waiting for the end of a sentence. The silence around the school wasn't a real silence. I could hear a flag rubbing against its pole, the faraway engine of some heavy vehicle, and Denys breathing through his nose because he was crying and didn't want anyone to see.

I took out my phone.

Since the spring, I had been working on a project for the school radio. It was going to be called *The Sounds of My Neighborhood*. I had recorded the baker knocking her paddle against the oven, the squeal of the tram, and the dog at number twelve, who could bark exactly three seconds after

the mail carrier passed. My radio teacher said I noticed the things other people overlooked.

I hit record.

Alina looked at the screen.

“What are you recording?”

“The bell.”

“But it isn’t ringing.”

“That’s the point.”

I held the phone up for a whole minute. On the file, you’d probably only hear my sleeve brushing the mic and a truck far away. Still, something had been kept: eight o’clock, in front of our school, the bell hadn’t rung, and we had come anyway.

On the way home, I passed some kids in their house clothes. One of them had a plastic gun. His mother yanked it out of his hands when a rumble rolled across the sky. We all looked up. It was only a plane, very high. Or maybe not. For months, the grownups had been answering “maybe” to questions that used to need a yes or a no.

Mama was waiting for me in front of the apartment door.

“Well?”

I kept my schoolbag on my shoulders.

“They’ll open later.”

She knew I was lying. I knew she knew. In our family, that sometimes counted as a whole conversation.

“Put your school things away,” she said softly. “We’ll keep them clean for when classes start again.”

I took out the red notebook.

“I need this one.”

“What for?”



I didn't have an answer yet. I went into my room, where Maksym's and Bohdan's beds had stayed perfectly made since they left. Maksym always left his socks under the radiator. Bohdan hid cookies in the textbook drawer. Mama had put everything away, as if tidiness could make it easier for them to come home.

I sat down at the desk. On the first page, I wrote the date and three names.

NOTEBOOK PAGE
To Papa, to Maksym, and to Bohdan.

School didn't open today.

I'd like to point out right away that I was wearing my uniform, and my blouse was better ironed than Maksym's shirt on his graduation day. So nobody can say the school closing is my fault.

At eight o'clock, the bell didn't ring.

I recorded the silence.

Papa will say you can't record a silence. Bohdan will say a microphone always records something. Maksym will say my file is going to be famous and he wants ten percent.

I'll play it for you when you come home.

I didn't write if.

I closed the notebook and laid my palm on its cover. In the kitchen, Mama was opening and closing the cupboards, counting our supplies. The baby kicked. She laughed to herself.

My schoolbag had been no use at all.

But it had carried the red notebook.

And the notebook had just found its job.

CHAPTER TWO

The City Speaks Softly

September 18



SOUND KEPT

stroller wheels on cobblestones.

Mama had turned the third floor landing into a library.

Two fruit crates covered with a blue sheet served as shelves. Kids came upstairs to pick out a book between air raid alerts. She wrote down every loan in a tiny notebook, just as carefully as she used to when she worked behind the big desk in the school library.

“What will you do if nobody brings the books back?” I asked her.

“I’ll send a very stern reminder letter.”

“The mail barely works anymore.”

“Then I’ll read it very loudly from the balcony.”

Her belly had gotten even bigger. When she bent down to reach the bottom crate, she had to lean on the wall. I saw

it. She saw that I saw it. We both pretended.

A little girl named Solomiya came up with her grandmother. She wanted a book about bears, but not a sad bear, not a lost bear, and definitely not a bear whose mother died at the end.

Mama dug around for a long time before she found the story of a bear who made soup that was much too salty.

“This one doesn’t lose anybody,” she promised.

Solomiya hugged the book to her chest.



That’s when I understood what Mama was really doing on the landing. She wasn’t only lending out stories. She was checking, page by page, that bearable endings still existed.

In the afternoon, Vira came up to inspect our windows. She pressed each strip of tape with her thumb.

“This one’s peeling.”

“Ihor put it up,” I said.

“I recognize his work. It has the mark of enthusiasm without skill.”

Ihor, who happened to be out on the balcony with a radio open on his knees, yelled:

“I can hear you!”

“Then fix your personality while you’re at it!”

He turned a knob. A voice drowned in static filled the room, then a few bars of an old song.

Mama went still. Vira recognized the tune before she did and started to hum. It lasted ten seconds. Then the station was gone.

“See?” Ihor said. “I can bring back the dead.”

Vira smacked the back of his head.

“We don’t joke about that.”

Ihor’s grin vanished. He looked down at his wires. I wanted to stick up for him, and then I thought of Papa and my brothers, and I hated Ihor for saying the word.

Later, Mama and I went to the makeshift market. The sellers spread their goods on boards laid across crates. There was a little of everything and a lot of people. The bread smelled of smoke. The apples were small and spotted. A puddle of fuel shone at the foot of a generator.

I recorded the sounds without looking like I was: coins counted twice, paper crinkling around cheese, a woman haggling over three onions as if she were negotiating a peace treaty.

A stroller crossed the square. Its wheels went clack-clack, clack-clack over the loose cobblestones. The baby inside was

sleeping through all the voices. Mama followed it with her eyes and put a hand on her own belly.

"Have you picked a name yet?" I asked.

"I have a list."

"That's not an answer."

"It's a librarian's answer. You compare several titles before you check one out."

She smiled, and then her face changed. She sat down on an empty crate.

"What's wrong?"

"Nothing. I walked too fast."

"You walked slower than Vira, and Vira stops to criticize every door."

"I'm pregnant, Katya. I get tired. That's been happening since mothers were invented."

Her lips had lost their color. I wanted to call someone, but she closed her fingers around my wrist.

"One minute."

I counted sixty seconds. At forty-three, she said I could stop. I kept going to sixty.

On the way home, my fear turned into anger. It was easier to carry.

"We should have left in July."

Mama pulled her coat tighter.

"We talked about that."

"No. You talked, and you decided. That's not the same."

"The road west was hit last week."

"And the bridge could close. Papa said so."

"Your father repairs railroad lines. He doesn't predict the future."

“At least he’s trying to get us out.”

She stopped walking.

I knew right away the sentence had found the exact spot where it would hurt.

“You think I’m staying because this apartment matters more to me than you do?”

I stared at the bag of apples so I wouldn’t have to look at her face.

“I think you’re waiting for a road that doesn’t exist.”

“Picking a road in wartime isn’t picking safety. It’s picking a danger you know less about.”

“So we just do nothing?”

“We wait for the evacuation they’ve announced. We pack the bags. We stay near Vira and the clinic as long as it’s open. And you stop believing that being scared makes you smarter than every grownup put together.”

We walked back to the building without speaking.

In the entryway, a message from Alina was waiting. Three kids from our class were meeting in the old sports club room. They had found some textbooks and wanted to set up lessons. I was putting on my shoes before I finished reading.

Then I heard Mama throwing up in the bathroom.

I stood outside the closed door.

“Go see your friends,” she said between breaths. “I’m fine.”

“You’re a bad liar.”

“That’s because I raised very suspicious children.”

I wrote to Alina that I couldn’t come. She sent back a yellow heart. I hated that heart. I hated Mama, then myself,

then the war, because it turned even a color into an accusation.

We spent the evening on the couch. Mama read the bear book out loud for Solomiya, who listened from the landing with two other kids. The bear kept putting way too much salt in the soup. Everybody laughed at every new spoonful, even though we already knew about the disaster.

	SOUND MAP OF THE APARTMENT
	<i>Kitchen: the faucet dripping. Papa has been promising to fix it for four years.</i>
	<i>Living room: Mama turns the pages faster when she gets close to a sad part.</i>
	<i>Hallway: three pencil marks on the wall. The highest one has Bohdan's name on it, at thirteen. Maksym says he was standing on tiptoe. Papa says he measured correctly. Nobody explains why the line slants.</i>
	<i>Bedroom: two empty beds that sometimes creak when the building shakes.</i>
	<i>Balcony: Ihor's radio looking for a voice in the noise.</i>
	<i>Inside Mama's belly: somebody knocking gently against the wall.</i>

I didn't write about our fight.
Back then, I still believed that what you didn't write down could disappear.

CHAPTER THREE

Three Messages

October 8



SOUND RESTORED

three knocks on a microphone.

The messages came on a Tuesday when almost nothing had happened.

The power had lasted three hours. Vira had burned a pot. Mama was sorting the landing books by size because she couldn't get into the school catalog anymore. I had tried to follow a lesson my math teacher sent, but the video always froze right when she was explaining the equation.

At 2:17, the phone buzzed on the table.

The first message was from Papa.

An engine nearly drowned out his voice. He spoke slowly, as if he were dictating a report: the crew was repairing a line, he was fine, we had to keep our papers in the evacuation bag. If the bridge closed, Mama shouldn't wait.

Then his voice changed.

“Kateryna, make sure your mother is resting. She thinks carrying a book is different from carrying a sack of potatoes. Explain to her that gravity never studied literature.”

Mama raised an eyebrow.

“Your father gets cheeky from a distance.”

I listened to the message three times. At the very end, right before it cut off, you could hear somebody calling Papa by name. His voice moved away without saying good-bye.

At 3:02, Maksym sent a voice note thirty-eight seconds long. He claimed he had lost a battle with a can of food and was calling for help from a librarian, a brilliant student, and at least one patriotic can opener.

“He works in a field hospital and he doesn’t have a can opener?” I asked.

“He probably has a can opener,” Mama said. “He just doesn’t have a better story.”

At 4:41, the third message arrived.

Bohdan’s voice was quieter than the others. He worked in communications for civil defense. He could fix an antenna, climb onto a roof, and stay silent for an hour. I could only manage one of those.

“Little Magpie, I got here safe.”

He called me that because I collected sounds the way other people collect shiny things.

“Don’t believe everything Maksym tells you. Unless he says I’m his favorite brother. That part is true.”

Something metal clanged behind him. Bohdan spoke to someone, too far from the mic for me to understand. Then he came back.

“I have to go. You know the rest.”

Three knocks hit the microphone.

| Knock. Knock. Knock.

When we were little, Bohdan used to hide behind my door and knock like that to warn me he was about to jump out. Even when I’d already spotted his shoes under the curtain, I had to pretend to be surprised. Later, the three knocks became our way of saying *I’m here* when a grownup was too close for secrets.

I held my phone near the table and answered with three taps of my fingernail.

Then I recorded three different replies.

For Papa, I put my voice away as neatly as my school blouse.

“We’re fine. The bags are ready. Mama is resting. I check the windows every night.”

For Maksym, I said his can had probably preferred to die sealed rather than get eaten by him.

For Bohdan, I told him about Ihor’s radio, the bear book, and the file I recorded at the school gate. I promised to play him all the sounds when he came home.

I didn’t tell anyone about the morning before, when Mama had to sit down on the floor between the kitchen and the living room because the room was spinning. I didn’t say that her hands shook sometimes. I didn’t say she woke up at night to check that the evacuation bag was still by the door.

Telling the truth would have carried our fear all the way to them. I didn’t want to add weight to what they were already carrying.

My lie looked like kindness.

That's how dangerous lies show up. They don't wear masks. They arrive holding a blanket and say: let me protect everyone.

That night, the air raid alert went off at 2:13. Mama and I sat on cushions in the hallway. She had my grandmother's shawl around her shoulders. Leaves and little stars were embroidered on the cloth. I rested my head against her. The baby moved between us.

"He kicks like Bohdan," I whispered.

"She," Mama said.

I lifted my head.

"You know it's a girl?"

"The doctor thinks so."

"And you didn't tell me?"

"I was waiting for you to ask a question that wasn't about my resting or the evacuation."

I put my hand on her belly. A little bump rolled under my palm.

"Can she hear the alert?"

"Probably."

"Then she'll think the world has always sounded like this."

Mama smoothed my hair.

"We'll teach her other sounds."

When the alert ended, she fell back asleep against the wall. I stayed awake with the phone in my hand.

THREE REPLIES I NEVER SENT

To Papa: *Mama is more tired than she tells you. So am I.*

To Maksym: *your stories don't always make me laugh. I listen to them to the end anyway, to hear whether your voice is shaking.*

To Bohdan: *when you knock three times, I'm afraid that one day the knocks will come without your voice.*

I deleted them in the morning.

For several weeks, every buzz of the phone made my heart jump. Then the messages came further apart. One day without news became two, then four. We made up technical reasons: dead battery, jammed network, crew moved somewhere else.

Nobody said the reason that didn't need any technology at all.

I kept filling the notebook for when they came home.

I didn't know yet that writing to someone and getting their answer are two completely different things.

CHAPTER FOUR

The Broken Bridge

November 28, before nightfall



LAST ELECTRIC SOUND

the hum of the refrigerator.

The refrigerator went quiet at 4:12. I know the time because I was recording its hum. For days, it had been making an uneven buzz that climbed one note and came back down. Bohdan might have known what was wrong with it. Mama said everybody gets old, and the refrigerator shouldn't think it was special.

At 4:12, the hum stopped in the middle of a note.

One second later, the windows shook.

A strike doesn't sound like it does in movies. There was no clean explosion and then a dramatic silence. There was a huge weight in the air, car alarms screaming, things falling in the neighbors' apartments, and a child howling on the stairs.

Mama grabbed the back of a chair.

"Into the hallway," I said.

She didn't move.

"Mama."

Her face had gone gray.

"It's nothing," she breathed. "A contraction."

"You said they weren't supposed to start for weeks."

"The baby didn't check the calendar."

A second contraction folded her in half.

I opened the door and called for Vira. She was already on the stairs, with a headlamp switched on and a bag in her hand.

"The bridge!" a neighbor shouted from the floor below.
"They hit the bridge!"

Vira came in without taking off her coat. She put two fingers on Mama's wrist, asked how long the pains had been coming, and then looked at her in that way that made lying impossible.

"Since this morning," Mama admitted.

I felt something tear inside me.

"This morning?"

"They were weak."

"You didn't tell me."

"Katya, not now," Vira cut in.

She sent me to get Ihor. I found him on the second floor, bent over the radio with two wires pinched between his fingers.

"We need to call an ambulance."

He saw my face and didn't ask a single useless question.

The phone lines were down. On the radio, voices came through in pieces: bridge impassable, fire near the river-

bank, civilian network priority. Ihor called the emergency post, repeated our address, waited. Every wait seemed longer than the last.

In the apartment, Vira had gotten Mama lying down. She asked for clean towels, water, basins, blankets. Her sentences were short. I ran from room to room and always came back with something almost right.

"The big towels, Katya."

"They're in the wardrobe."

"Then why are you giving me a dish towel?"

I stared at the cloth in my hands as if it had appeared there on its own.

"Breathe," Vira said.

"Mama's the one having the baby."

"And you're the one who stopped breathing."

A neighbor, Uncle Serhiy, offered to carry Mama down on a door to the square, where a vehicle might be able to get close. Vira asked which road was still open. Nobody knew. Strikes were still going on in the distance. The stairway was dark and covered in chunks of plaster.

Mama shook her head.

"I can't walk."

Her voice didn't sound like her voice anymore.

Downstairs, people were heading into the basement. They were calling to us. I looked at the apartment door, then at Mama, then at the evacuation bag that had been waiting there for months.

I had always believed that in a disaster, the right choice would show up clearly. A green arrow. A competent person.

A plan. There were only several dangers, and grownups who didn't know any more than I did.

"I'm staying," I said.

Mama closed her eyes.

"You should go down."

"I'm staying."

This time, Vira didn't argue.

Ihor finally got an answer. A rescuer's voice came through the static. The main bridge was destroyed. A team was looking for another way across, but nobody could give a time. Vira described the situation in words I didn't all understand.

The voice answered something about the birth, the signs to watch for, and what supplies we had.

Then the signal vanished.

Ihor smacked the radio.

"Come back," he muttered. "Come on, come back."

Mama cried out from the bedroom.

Vira handed me a flashlight.

"You're going to stay by her head. You shine the light where I tell you. You don't touch anything unless I say so. And if you don't understand, you tell me."

"I understand."

"No. You want to understand. That's not the same."

She laid her hand on my cheek for a second.

"But you can help me."

I wanted to ask if Mama was going to die. The words got stuck behind my teeth.

At 5:03, it was already pitch dark.

At 5:18, our phones had almost no signal left.

At 5:31, Ihor’s lamp flickered.

At 5:46, Mama called me Tetiana, her own mother’s name.

I stopped counting the minutes.

	INVENTORY BEFORE NIGHTFALL
	One headlamp.
	Two candles, one of them vanilla, because Mama was saving it for a birthday.
	A radio that picks up more static than voices.
	Clean sheets.
	Water that cools off too fast.
	Vira.
	Ihor behind the door, hunting for a signal.
	Me, fourteen, sure until tonight that grownups knew what came next.
	Mama, squeezing my hand hard enough to hurt.
	Someone who wants to be born in a city without light.

CHAPTER FIVE

The Night Without a Bridge

The night of November 28



NEW SOUND

a cry that refuses silence.

The vanilla candle burned on a saucer by the bed. For years, that smell had meant a cake was coming. That night it mixed with hot wax, damp laundry, and dust. Every time the building shook, the flame leaned toward the taped window.

I held the flashlight.

That's what I did while Anastasiya was being born. I didn't save my mother. I didn't understand what Vira's hands were doing. I wasn't brave every second. I held a light, brought whatever they asked for, and counted breaths, because counting was the only thing my brain still knew how to do.

Mama asked for water. Then she said she didn't want it. She called for Papa, apologized, yelled at Vira, and ordered

me out of the room.

"No," I said.

"For once in your life, do what I say."

"You raised me to argue. Live with the consequences."

Her lips moved as if she were about to smile. A pain went through her before she could.

Vira never spoke louder than she had to. She told Mama when to breathe, when to push, when to save her strength. Several times, she asked Ihor to try the rescuers again. He answered from the hallway: nothing, still nothing, I'm still trying.

Once, a voice came back on the radio. Vira asked questions. Half the answers got lost in the hiss. I heard *north road, team stuck, keep us posted*. Then the channel died again.

The hours stopped moving forward. They piled up.

Mama squeezed my wrist.

"Katya. Look at me."

I pointed the flashlight at her face.

"Not that light in my eyes. Your face."

I leaned in close.

"I'm scared," she said.

My mother never said that. She said *I'm worried, we need to think, we'll see tomorrow*. Fear belonged to children, and to the books she closed after promising us a better ending.

"Me too."

"Good."

"Good?"

"At least we're not wasting time lying to each other."

I told her anything at all to fill the space between contractions: Solomiya had finally returned the bear book, Ihor still hadn't fixed the second floor radio, I had hidden two sugar cubes in Bohdan's drawer. Mama already knew every one of those stories. She listened anyway.

Then Vira said:

"Oksana, now."

The world shrank down to her voice.

A moment later, something very small appeared between Vira's hands.

The baby wasn't crying.

Nobody was breathing.

Vira rubbed her with a cloth, cleared her face, and spoke to her in a stern voice, as if the child had broken a rule in her very first second.

"Come on, little one. You made it this far. Finish your entrance."

I heard a tiny sound. Not a cry yet. A crumpled complaint.

Then the baby opened her mouth.

Her cry filled the room.

Ihor dropped something out in the hallway. Mama laughed once, very weakly.

"A girl?" she asked.

"A girl," Vira said.

They showed her to me. Her face was scrunched up, furious, almost purple. She was waving a fist so small my thumb could have covered it.

"She's mad," I said.

“Then she really does belong to this family,” Mama whispered.

For a few seconds, we thought the worst was over.

Then Vira looked at the bed.

I won't describe everything that happened. I remember the change in her face, the cloth she asked for, her hands working fast. Most of all, I remember what she said to Ihor: we need a team, medicine, blood.

He ran for the radio.

Mama started to shake.

“Why is she shaking?”

“Cover her.”

“Why?”

“Katya, the blanket.”

I did what she said. The baby was crying on a towel next to Vira. I wanted to pick her up, and I never wanted to touch her. Both of those truths lived in my body at the same time.

Vira gave instructions I followed without understanding them. Her hands never stopped. She kept calling Mama by her name. She asked Ihor where the team was. He said the way through was still blocked.

At one point, Mama stopped shaking.

That scared me more than everything else.

Her eyelids opened. Her eyes searched the room.

“The baby?”

Vira handed her to me, wrapped in a towel and the embroidered shawl.

I held her too high against my chest. Her head flopped back. Vira caught it right away.

“There. Always the head.”

Mama was watching us.

“Come closer,” she whispered.

I sat on the edge of the bed with the baby. Her eyes were shut. Her mouth was searching for something against the cloth.

Mama laid two fingers on her cheek.

“My little one,” she said.

I didn’t know which of us she meant.

“Mama, the rescuers are coming.”

Her eyes moved to me.

“Listen to Vira.”

“I’m listening to her.”

“Not just now. After.”

“After what?”

She took a breath. Every breath seemed to have to squeeze through a door that was too narrow.

“You’re her sister.”

“I know.”

“Not her mother.”

I held the baby tighter.

“Don’t say that.”

“A sister can love without disappearing.”

“You’ll explain it to her yourself.”

She closed her eyes. I called her until she opened them again.

“Find the others,” she breathed. “Don’t carry it all...”

The end of her sentence never came.



Vira told me to leave the room. I refused. She said my name in a voice I had never heard before. Ihor came in and took me by the shoulders. I gave him the baby because my arms had stopped answering me.

In the hallway there were neighbors, lamps, blankets, and far too many faces. Someone was talking to me. The baby was crying. I stared at the bedroom door.

Vira's silence lasted less than a minute.

I knew before she came out.

She took off her headlamp. It had left a red line across her forehead.

"Katya..."

I stepped back.

"No."

Vira opened her arms.

"No. Go back in there. Start over."

She didn't say she had done everything she could. She didn't say Mama was gone or that she wasn't in pain anymore. The sentences people keep ready for death couldn't fit inside our apartment.

She only said:

"I'm so sorry."

Then the baby let out a sharper cry in Ihor's arms.

I turned toward the baby.

Her face was red. Her fists were trembling. She didn't know our mother had just died. She didn't know the world was missing a bridge. All she knew was that she was cold and hungry and nobody was answering fast enough.

I took her back.

I didn't do it because I was brave.

I did it because she was crying.

NIGHT ZERO
Time unknown.

Mama is dead.

The baby is breathing.

Those two sentences refuse to live on the same page. And yet neither of them will leave.

I won't write her name until I know it.

I'm only calling her *the baby*.

If I write *my sister*, then Mama really is mother to both of us.

If I write *our mother*, then she really is dead.

The baby is breathing.

I put two fingers under her nose to check.

Vira says to stop.

I do it again as soon as she looks away.

CHAPTER SIX

The Name in the Candle

November 29 to December 15



SOUND HELD

a breath against my chest.

After Mama died, everyone knew what to do except me. Vira kept the baby covered. Ihor carried water. Uncle Serhiy went up and down the stairs looking for news of the rescuers. One neighbor washed linens. Another had found a little bottle of water that was still sealed.

I sat on a chair with the baby in my arms and stared at the bedroom door.

“Katya, open your coat,” Vira said.

I didn’t move.

She said it three times. The third time, she knelt down in front of me.

“She’s losing heat. We’re going to put her against you.”

“Mama’s in there.”

“I know.”

"She's all alone."

Vira's face came apart for one second. Then the old midwife came back.

"Oksana isn't alone. Tetiana is with her. You're with the baby."

She helped me place the tiny body against my skin, under my blouse and the shawl. The baby was lighter than my schoolbag. Her cheek settled under my collarbone. She was breathing so fast I thought she must be scared.

"It's too fast."

"Newborns breathe faster than we do."

"How many exactly?"

"Katya."

"How many?"

Vira understood that I wasn't asking for a number. She put her hand on the back of my neck.

"For now, she's breathing. We're watching her."

Before dawn, a woman came down from the fourth floor. Mariya had given birth three months earlier. She was carrying her own son wrapped in a yellow blanket.

"Vira told me the baby needs to eat."

I sat up straight.

"She can't leave."

"I'm not taking her anywhere."

Mariya sat down across from me and explained what she could do. Her voice was gentle, which made me angry right away. People talk softly around orphans, as if a normal word might break them.

"No," I said.

The baby turned her head against my chest, looking for something I couldn't give her.

Vira didn't try to win me over with beautiful sentences.

"If you refuse help because you're hurting, she's the one who'll go hungry."

I hated Vira.

I handed the baby to Mariya.

I stayed close enough to take my sister back at the slightest movement. Mariya didn't comment. Her son was asleep in another neighbor's arms. When the baby finally calmed down, my relief was followed by a jealousy so violent I was ashamed.

In a few minutes, Mariya had managed what I couldn't do at all.

"She doesn't like her better," Vira said without looking at me.

"I didn't say anything."

"Your face speaks with a very clear accent."

In the morning, volunteers managed to reach our neighborhood by a back road. They brought supplies, safe water, and formula. A nurse examined the baby and explained the signs that would mean we had to get her out right away. Vira listened. I wrote down every word in the red notebook, as if good spelling could protect a life.

I won't copy those notes here. They weren't a recipe for survival. Without Mariya, Vira, the nurse, the volunteers, and all the hands that heated water or scrubbed a bottle clean, my sister wouldn't have made it through her first days.

Mama's funeral was held in the inner courtyard during a lull.

There weren't enough flowers. Mama would have said flowers were useless in winter and it was better to buy books, so the children brought photocopied pages of poems she loved. Solomiya laid a drawing of a bear on the coffin.

Before they closed the coffin, I slipped the library bookmark into her coat pocket: a cardboard rectangle with a black cat and the words *One more chapter*. She always left it sticking out of novels.

I wanted to say something. No word was big enough, and I refused the words that were too small.

So I put my hand on the wood and knocked three times.

The sound was dull.

Nothing answered.

For several days, we called my sister *the baby*. Vira said we had to fill out the volunteers' forms. I insisted that Mama had picked a name, even though I didn't know what it was.

We searched the nightstand and found a folded sheet of paper tucked in a book. Eight names were written on it.

EIGHT NAMES FOR A GIRL
Sofiya. Crossed out. Maksym said there had been three in his class and people would always end up calling the wrong one.
Mariya. Circled, then crossed out. Our neighbor had that name. She said a name could belong to more than one person. I said the baby already had enough people in her life without sharing her name.
Yelyzaveta. A question mark. Too long, according to Papa. He forgot that our last name already had nine letters and had survived.
Polina. Nothing next to it.
Iryna. A star.
Daria. Two lines.
Viktoriya. Maksym had added: only if she wins something. Underneath, Mama had written: She'll have been born. That's enough.
Anastasiya. An arrow and three words: We rise again.

I chose that one.

Not because I wanted her to spend her life getting back up. I wanted her to be able to stay in bed on some Sundays, refuse to clean her room, and complain that nobody understood her problems. But Mama had left those words next to that name, and I had nothing else she had chosen for the baby.

"Anastasiya," I tried.

The baby frowned.

"Nastia?" Ihor suggested from the doorway.

She kept frowning.

"She hates both," he concluded.

"She mostly hates you."

"She's a very perceptive child."

For the first time since the night without a bridge, a little puff of air came out of my nose. It wasn't a laugh, but Ihor was smart enough not to point it out.

I wrote the name on the form. The box was too short. I had to write smaller at the end. Her identity was already spilling past the spaces made for it.

That night, I opened the notebook to a fresh page.

A PRAYER WITHOUT A BARGAIN

God,

I'm not going to thank you for the baby as if you had nothing to do with the rest.

I'm not going to say you needed Mama. We needed her more.

All I ask is that you don't take anyone else today. Tomorrow I'll ask about tomorrow.

Protect Papa, Maksym, and Bohdan. If you can't, say so honestly.

And help me not to let Anastasiya down.

I heard nothing after that prayer. No answer, no sign, no music. Only the baby breathing under the shawl.

A few days later, an aid worker came with evacuation forms. A convoy was going to leave for a village called Lypove. Minors couldn't travel without a responsible adult.

"Baba Vira will go with you," the woman said.

"I can take care of my sister."

"I don't doubt it. But you're fourteen."

I hated that sentence. I was fourteen when people didn't let me decide things, and forty when Anastasiya cried at three in the morning.

Vira sat down beside me.

“I won’t take your mother’s place.”

“Nobody can.”

“Good. Then we agree. I’ll be the designated adult responsible for you during the trip. You’ll stay her sister. And we’ll argue whenever we need to.”

“That’ll be a lot.”

“I’m counting on it.”

I looked at the line on the form: *Relationship to child.*

I wrote *sister*.

The word looked too small to hold everything I had just promised.

That same evening, the evacuation order was posted in the entryway.

One person. One bag.

Departure before dawn.

In my room, the schoolbag was waiting under the desk.

This time, it was going to be of use.

PART TWO

Breath in Winter



December to February

Chapters 7–12

CHAPTER SEVEN

A Place on the Truck

December 16



SOUND CARRIED OFF

*the apartment door slamming one last
time.*

One person, one bag.
The rule had been printed in capital letters on the evacuation order, as if capital letters made something easier to accept.

I emptied my wardrobe onto the floor. My winter clothes made a pile on the left. Anastasiya's things took up almost the whole rug: diapers, cloths, bottles, cans of formula, blankets, little outfits the neighbor women had given us. In the middle, I had put the red notebook, my phone, its charger that was useless whenever the power went out, and the little recorder from the school radio.

On the right was everything I couldn't defend with the word necessary.

My certificate from the science competition. A gold plastic medal. The novel Bohdan gave me for my twelfth birthday. Three letters from Papa. Maksym's sweatshirt, way too big, which I'd stolen two winters before. A seashell I brought back from the sea when I was six. Mama's chipped mug with the words *Five more minutes and one more chapter*.

Every object I picked sentenced the others to stay behind.

"You're packing a bag, not an ark," Ihor said from the doorway.

"Thanks. I was just hoping to save two of every sock."

He crouched down next to the pile.

"The science prize can stay."

"I know."

"Then why are you holding it?"

I realized the medal was shut tight in my fist.

"Because I won it before everybody started handing out congratulations for things like finding water."

Ihor didn't answer right away.

"You won it even if you don't take it with you."

I set the medal on Bohdan's bed. I wanted it to be the first thing he saw when he came home. I didn't think about how dust might cover it, or someone else might move into the apartment, or there might not even be a bed when Bohdan got back. I arranged the ribbon around the medal as if everything else depended on it.

Vira came in with Anastasiya under the shawl. My sister was asleep with her mouth open, completely uninterested in the sorting of our old life.

“The volunteers want our documents in an outside pocket,” Vira said. “They don’t want to stand around while a teenager empties out her soul at the checkpoint.”

“My soul doesn’t fit in a pocket.”

“Very impractical.”

She looked over the things on the floor without rushing me. Then she picked up the photograph lying next to the notebook. All five of us were in it, squeezed together in front of a lake, squinting in the sun. Mama was laughing because Papa had set the timer too short and he was still running toward us. Half of his body was a blur.

“That one,” I said.

Vira slid it into a plastic sleeve. I didn’t see her take two other photos too. I only found out later, when they fell out of her pocket into the snow on the road to Lypove: Mama at twenty, and my brothers on the roof of our building.

I filled my schoolbag with what kept Anastasiya alive. Formula first. The bottles. The clothes. Mariya’s yellow blanket. Then the shawl, which Vira refused to count as an object because it was on us. I added the notebook and the photograph. My phone went into the small pocket with its earbuds.

The recorder wouldn’t fit anymore.

I took out a pair of socks. It still didn’t fit.

I tried putting it in sideways. The zipper wouldn’t close.

“Katya,” Ihor said.

“I know.”

“You can record with your phone.”

“It isn’t the same.”

He took the recorder, wrapped it in Maksym's sweat-shirt, and slipped it into his own bag.

"I'm not taking much."

"You've got your radio."

"That doesn't count. It's my impractical soul."

We left the apartment before dawn.

Vira went down the stairs first with Anastasiya. Ihor carried both our bags. I stayed in the entryway with my hand on the light switch until I remembered the electricity didn't work anymore.

The kitchen still smelled of cold tea. On the hallway wall, my brothers' height marks leaned toward the door. The crates of books were waiting on the landing. The book about the bear and the salty soup wasn't on the pile anymore.

I closed the door.

The sound of the lock was smaller than I'd imagined.

At the evacuation point, families stood in line around a gray truck. Volunteers checked names, papers, and the number of bags. A boy was hugging an empty birdcage. His mother kept saying they'd had to leave the bird with a neighbor. I didn't know why they were bringing the cage. I didn't ask.

When our turn came, the volunteer looked over my birth certificate, Anastasiya's, and the form Vira had signed.

"The responsible adult is Vira Bondarenko?"

"I'm the one who takes care of the baby," I said.

The woman looked at me, then at Anastasiya.

"I understand. I still need Mrs. Bondarenko's signature."

I had fed my sister at two in the morning. I had learned to recognize the sound she made before she cried. I had buried our mother. Even so, a printed line decided that my word had to go through an adult.

Vira signed.

I resented her for being able to.

She didn't apologize.

Inside the truck, benches had been bolted along the sides. Ihor sat across from us. I kept the bag between my feet and Anastasiya under my coat. Through the opening at the back, I watched our neighborhood shrink.

I thought I would recognize the last moment our building was still in sight. But a turn in the road erased it without warning.

WHAT STAYED BEHIND

The science medal on Bohdan's bed.

Mama's mug by the sink.

The seashell in the desk drawer.

The landing books, sorted by size.

Two beds waiting for boys who had become men somewhere else.

An apartment that still knew the shape of our family.

WHAT CAME WITH US

Formula. Papers. One photograph. The notebook.

The shawl around Anastasiya.

Vira, who had signed.

Ihor, who was carrying my voice in his bag.

Me, who hadn't signed, but who was leaving anyway.

CHAPTER EIGHT

Twelve Kilometers of Snow

December 16, on the road



SOUND KEPT

footsteps looking for the same rhythm.

The truck broke down in the middle of a sentence. The driver was telling us that Lypove still had a stove, a water tank, and a basement big enough for all of us. He'd said, "If the road holds, we'll be there before..."

The engine coughed three times and died.

For a few seconds, nobody moved. The wind was pushing snow against the canvas of the truck. Anastasiya was asleep against me. I put two fingers under her nose.

Vira saw what I was doing.

"She's breathing."

"I'm checking."

"You check every thirty seconds."

"Then my information is very up to date."

The driver and Ihor climbed down. Through the opening, I could see their legs in the snow and the flashlight moving around under the hood. The smell of fuel came in with the cold. Several kids woke up.

After twenty minutes, the driver climbed back in.

"I can't fix it here. Lypove is twelve kilometers away."

A woman laughed. Not because anything was funny. It was the sound a person makes when bad news turns out bigger than expected.

"With the children?" someone asked.

"The temperature's going to drop. Staying in the truck is more dangerous."

We strapped up the bags, wrapped the little ones in blankets, and formed a group. The adults who could walk went first. The older people and the parents with children stayed in the middle. The driver brought up the rear.

Vira tied the shawl around my chest to hold Anastasiya under my coat. She pulled the cloth tight until I complained.

"I need to be able to breathe."

"So does she. Tell me if something bothers you."

"Everything bothers me."

"Make a more specific complaint."

We started walking.

The snow swallowed the road. At first, I counted steps. One hundred, then two hundred. I started over at zero when we went around an abandoned car. I was also counting Anastasiya's breaths, but mine kept getting mixed up with hers. Every gust of wind wiped out the voices ahead of us.

Ihor walked on my left with two bags. He had wrapped his scarf all the way up to his eyes.

"Do you want me to take a bag?" I asked.

"You're carrying a person."

"She weighs less than a bag."

"She complains more."

As if to prove him right, Anastasiya woke up and let out a cry under my coat. I stopped immediately.

"Keep walking," Vira said. "I'll look."

She slid a hand under the cloth, checked the baby's position, and fixed her blanket. I didn't like her touching Anastasiya without asking me. I didn't like needing her hands either.

After several kilometers, a man named Mykola fell. He had tried to carry his own bag and his wife's, because her ankle was hurt. The whole group stopped. The driver wanted to leave some of the luggage at the side of the road. Nobody offered theirs.

In the end we opened the bags to spread the weight around. Clothes were stacked under a tarp. A pot got tied to the outside of a bag. The boy with the empty birdcage refused to leave it. Ihor ended up hanging it from his shoulder.

The wind picked up.

My arms were starting to shake. I held Anastasiya tight against me, and still I could feel her weight sliding down. The shawl was holding her body, but I felt as if only my hands were keeping the world from taking her.

"Give her to me," Vira said.

"No."

“Katya.”

“I can walk.”

I took three steps. My boot slipped. Ihor caught me by the elbow.

Anastasiya started to scream.

Vira opened her coat.

“I’m not asking you to abandon her. I’m asking you to let me carry her to the next pole.”

The pole was so far away it looked like a pencil line stuck in the snow.

“And after that?”

“After that, we’ll decide how much longer we can keep lying to ourselves.”

I wanted to say I wasn’t lying. My legs shook instead.

Vira took Anastasiya. The shawl went from my body to hers. For a second, the cold hit my damp chest. Then another feeling arrived: relief.

I could straighten my back. I could open my hands. I could walk without watching every jolt.

I was ashamed of that relief.

I took one of Ihor’s bags to punish myself.

“You know that doesn’t fix anything,” he said.

“Shut up.”

“I can shut up and be right at the same time.”

We made it to the pole. Anastasiya was asleep against Vira. She hadn’t noticed I was gone.

“She’s fine,” Vira said.

I took her back immediately.

A few hundred meters farther on, I had to hand her over again. The second time hurt less. That seemed worse.



Night was falling when we spotted a light between the trees. Not an electric light. A flame behind a covered window. Somebody at the front of the group shouted. The others answered. Our voices passed all the way down the line to the back, like a rope stretched out in the wind.

The old school in Lypove had lost several windows and part of its roof. But smoke was rising from the chimney. A woman was waiting for us at the door with a lamp.

When we went inside, the heat hurt my cheeks.

I looked at Vira, then at Ihor, then at the people covered in snow filing one by one into the hallway.

We had walked twelve kilometers.

Nobody had walked them alone.

TWELVE KILOMETERS, WRITTEN AFTERWARD	
	Kilometer one: I still thought I could count everything.
	Kilometer three: snow got into my left boot.
	Kilometer five: Mykola fell, and all the bags changed owners.
	Kilometer seven: Vira carried Anastasiya.
	Kilometer eight: I found out relief can feel like betrayal.
	Kilometer nine: I handed her over a second time.
	Kilometer eleven: someone started a song nobody knew the second verse of.
	Kilometer twelve: the light of Lypove.
	The real distance: the one between "I have to" and "we can."

CHAPTER NINE

The Cellar of Seven Families

January 12



SOUND RESTORED

*chalk on a blackboard over the rum-
bling.*

The cellar was built to store coal, not families. The people of Lypove had hung blankets between the pillars to make rooms. Each space held two mattresses, bags, and things saved at the last minute. At the back, a stove glowed red in an old storeroom. A smell of wet wool, soup, and smoke lived in our clothes.

Six families had settled there, some since the fall, others off the same truck as us. We became the seventh, even though nobody could agree on what Vira, Ihor, Anastasiya, and I added up to.

“A family,” said Ihor.

“An administrative disaster,” I said.

Vira approved of both definitions.

A school blackboard had been carried down into the cellar. On it, people wrote turns for fetching water, fuel rations, and chores. Vira added our names in chalk.

“Everyone works,” she announced. “Even the children, according to their age. Even the adults, according to their bad moods.”

I was put in charge of washing bottles and keeping the supply log. I agreed because numbers calmed me. I could write: eight cans of formula, six opened, two sealed. Fifty-seven diapers. Fourteen liters of safe water. The numbers didn’t promise anything, but at least they had the good manners to stay where they belonged.

I wouldn’t let anyone else give Anastasiya her bottle.

Vira let three days go by before she challenged me.

“You can’t keep the log, wash the equipment, and feed the baby all at once.”

“I can if nobody interrupts me.”

“Babies rarely study that rule.”

A woman named Nina had been holding Anastasiya for a few minutes. She offered to keep holding her while I counted supplies. I answered too fast.

“She doesn’t like strangers.”

Anastasiya had been sleeping peacefully in Nina’s arms for five minutes.

“She hides her opinion well,” Vira remarked.

I took my sister back.

In the next room, a displaced teacher named Olena Petrivna had set up an hour of lessons. The little ones traced letters on paper already used on the other side. The older

ones took turns reading aloud. I walked past them with my bottles as if school were contagious.

One morning, Olena Petrivna handed me a worksheet.

"Twenty minutes."

"I have to sterilize the bottles."

"They're drying right behind you."

"Anastasiya's going to eat soon."

"Nina knows how to give her a bottle."

"She doesn't know the right angle."

Olena Petrivna looked at Vira.

Vira took the baby.

"Twenty minutes," she said.

I realized a conspiracy had been organized.

I sat at the end of a bench. The first problem was an equation I could have solved in September without lifting my pencil. The numbers looked familiar, but their order kept slipping away from me. I started three times. My hand was sweating.

Next to me, Pavlo, who was nine, had already finished.

"Want me to explain it?" he whispered.

"No."

The word came out so hard that Pavlo flinched.

I wasn't just behind. I had turned stupid. The war had eaten chunks of my brain while I was counting diapers.

Olena Petrivna crouched down beside me.

"You know this method."

"Apparently not."

"Your mind is watching ten dangers at once. It'll take time before it agrees to look at only one."

"Numbers aren't dangerous."

“Fear doesn’t always file things in the right folders.”

She covered the bottom of the sheet with her hand.

“One line. Not the whole exercise.”

I solved the first line. Then the second.

When the twenty minutes were up, Anastasiya was still asleep against Vira. Nothing terrible had happened while I turned back into a student.

That evening, I copied the names of the people in the cellar onto a page. I didn’t want us to turn into nothing but mattresses, rations, and spots near the stove.

THE PEOPLE IN THE CELLAR
Nina knows four ways to save a match and sings out of tune while she makes soup.
Mykola claims his fall in the snow was a scientific demonstration.
Pavlo is nine, maybe ten according to him, and finishes his work before me without having the decency to apologize.
Solomiya, who came from our neighborhood with her grandmother, sleeps with the bear book under her blanket. She drew a library above her mattress.
Olena Petrivna keeps teaching even when the artillery rumbles. She waits for the noise to move off, then picks up at the exact word where she stopped.
Ihor fixes the outlets in a school that has no electricity.
Vira keeps a sugar cube in her pocket for an emergency she refuses to define.
Anastasiya likes deep voices and wakes up every time I sit down to eat.
Katya keeps this list because she’s afraid of forgetting people before she even loses them.

Above us, the old school stayed closed.

Down in the cellar, class had begun again.

CHAPTER TEN

When the Ink Froze

January 29 to February 3



SOUND KEPT

charcoal scratching paper.

The cold took my pen during the night. I rubbed the tip against my palm, blew on it, shook the barrel until I flung a blue spot onto the cover. The ink refused to come down.

“It’s on strike,” Ihor said.

“It’s frozen.”

“It’s a climate strike.”

He handed me a piece of charcoal wrapped in a rag.

“For your masterpiece. Great writers always suffer.”

“Great writers have pens.”

“That’s why they have no personality.”

The charcoal blackened my fingers and left dust on the page. I had to write big. The words looked like someone

else's, someone in more of a hurry and less careful. I kept going anyway.

Ihor was working on a piece of wood he'd rescueded from a classroom. He wouldn't tell me what he was making. Two days later, he showed off a bird whose left wing was shorter than its right.

"Did it survive an accident?" I asked.

"It's a rare species."

"The species I *didn't measure before I cut?*"

"Exactly. It only flies in circles."

He hung the bird above Anastasiya's basket. The toy turned whenever a draft slipped under the door. My sister followed it with her eyes, with a seriousness that gave Ihor an importance he didn't deserve.

The first smile came three days later.

Vira was holding Anastasiya near the stove and telling her a story about a goat that refused to go back into the barn. I was sorting supplies a couple of meters away. At one point, Vira imitated the goat's bleat.

Anastasiya opened her mouth, and her cheeks lifted.

Vira stopped.

"Did you see that?"

I had seen it.

The smile disappeared almost right away, then came back when Vira made her ridiculous noise again.

Everybody gathered around. Nina called Ihor over. Pavlo claimed the baby was smiling at him. The grownups were laughing, and Vira's eyes were shining.

I didn't feel anything beautiful.

I had been waiting for that smile. I had fed Anastasiya at night, warmed her feet, counted her breaths, washed her clothes. I had believed it would belong to me.

Jealousy went through me so violently that I left the cellar.

Outside, the air cut my throat. I hid behind the back stairs and scrubbed my hands, black with charcoal, in the snow.

Mama would have been better with her.

That thought held two cruelties. It used a dead woman to judge me, and it turned Anastasiya into a test I was failing.

Vira found me without a coat, which gave her a practical reason to start by scolding me.

"Do you want to lose two fingers to top off this day?"

She threw her wool shawl over my shoulders.

"Go back to her," I said.

"She's with Nina."

"She smiles at everybody but me."

Vira leaned against the wall.

"Yes."

I expected her to say that wasn't true, that the baby loved me more, that my turn would come. Her agreeing made me look up.

"That's it?"

"Would you rather have a lie?"

"I'd rather not be jealous of a woman who's sixty-six."

"So would I. It gives me far too much power."

In spite of myself, I smiled.

Vira looked at my hands.

"How many hours are you sleeping?"

“Enough.”

“How many?”

I didn’t answer.

“Exhaustion bends love out of shape,” she said. “It turns a smile into a debt and a helping hand into an accusation. That doesn’t make you a monster. It means you need to sleep.”

“And if she needs me?”

“Then I’ll wake you.”

“And if you don’t notice something?”

Vira’s face closed.

“I was noticing things before you were born, Katya.”

I understood too late that my fear had just hit her own guilt. She still thought about Mama every time she closed her eyes. She also believed that one more minute of watching might have changed the night without a bridge.

“Four hours,” she said. “Not so you’ll trust me. So you’ll admit your body exists.”

I lay down behind our blanket. I kept my clothes and shoes on and one hand on the notebook. The voices of the cellar went on around me.

I woke up because someone was laughing.

Four hours and seventeen minutes had gone by.

Anastasiya was asleep. The shelter hadn’t burned down. Nobody had run off with her. On the table, Nina had made a dessert with dark flour and Vira’s sugar cube. It had sunk in the middle and stuck to your teeth.

“So that was the emergency?” I asked Vira.

“We were alive and we had sugar. I didn’t see a reason to wait for anything worse.”

We shared the dessert in tiny portions. Ihor claimed it could be used to patch the cracks in the ceiling. Olena Petrivna took seconds.

Anastasiya woke up while I was eating. I held her against me.

She didn't smile.

But she put her hand on my chin and went back to sleep.

That was enough for me.



LIST OF FORBIDDEN FEELINGS
Being jealous of Vira.
Feeling relieved when someone else carries Anastasiya.
Wanting to sleep while she's crying.
Sometimes finding her crying unbearable.
Laughing at a joke while Mama is dead.
Loving the failed dessert.
Wanting to go back to school.

I showed the list to Vira.

She took the charcoal and added:

| *Banning feelings as if they asked permission.*

Then she wrote underneath:

| *Actions count. Feelings pass. Go to sleep.*

CHAPTER ELEVEN

Breathing Too Fast

February 13 and 14



DANGEROUS SOUND

*breathing that leaves no silence between
breaths.*

I noticed the cough before anyone else.

At first, it was just a small dry sound after her bottle. I wiped the milk off Anastasiya's chin and waited. She coughed a second time, then fell asleep.

The next day, her nose was running. Her skin was warm. She was drinking less and waking up crying. I put my palm on her chest. It was rising too fast.

I knew the signs. The nurse had explained them to us after she was born. Vira had gone over them again. I had written everything down.

I also knew what Nina had heard at the distribution point: when a child got seriously sick, they could be evacuated to a hospital, with no guarantee of a place for the whole family.

I pictured a vehicle taking Anastasiya away. A door closing between us. An adult promising to send news. Then the network going down.

So I picked another explanation.

She was tired.

The cellar was too dry.

All babies caught colds.

I kept her close. I offered her the bottle more often. I wrote down every feeding and every diaper. I didn't tell Vira her breathing was getting faster.

That evening, she asked me:

"Did she eat well?"

"A little less."

"Any fever?"

"She's warm because she was under the shawl."

That wasn't exactly a lie. She had been under the shawl. Lies know how to use facts like bricks.

During the night, I sat up against the wall. Anastasiya slept in short stretches. Her chest was sinking in a way I didn't want to look at. I counted her breaths and started over every time the number seemed impossible.

Ihor got up to feed the stove.

"Why are you still awake?"

"She's hungry."

"She's asleep."

"She just finished."

He came closer. The light from the stove touched Anastasiya's face.

"She's breathing weird."

"No, she isn't."

“Katya.”

“Wake Vira and I’ll never speak to you again.”

Ihor hesitated.

I watched him choose between my anger and the baby.

He crossed the cellar and pulled back Vira’s curtain.

I hated him with a strength that almost felt like relief.

Vira examined Anastasiya under the lamp. She asked questions. How long had she been coughing? How much had she drunk? When had the fever started?

With every answer, her face got calmer. With Vira, calm meant danger.

“We have to go to the clinic,” she said.

“She’s better when I hold her.”

“She needs to be examined and treated.”

“They’ll separate us.”

“We’ll ask for you to stay with her.”

“Asking doesn’t guarantee anything.”

Vira wrapped Anastasiya in the blanket.

“How long have you known?”

“I just noticed,” I lied.

Ihor looked down.

The silence between us answered for me.

“How long?” Vira asked again.

“Yesterday. Maybe before.”

“And you didn’t say anything?”

“I was watching her.”

“Watching isn’t treating.”

“I wanted to protect her.”

Vira came so close I could see the red veins in her eyes.

“What are you protecting now, Katya? Your sister or your secret?”

The question stopped me cold.

I looked at Anastasiya. Her nostrils flared with every breath. She didn’t have enough energy left to cry.

“My sister,” I said.

“Then tell the whole truth.”

I told them about the first cough, the refused bottle, the fever, the hours spent counting. I said it in front of Vira, Ihor, and the people our voices had woken up. Every detail made me guiltier and made their decision more certain.

The clinic was about thirty kilometers away. The shelter had a vehicle, but almost no fuel left. That same fuel also ran the generator for the space heaters when it got too cold.

Mykola woke up the heads of the families.

I held Anastasiya while they gathered by the blackboard.

For the first time, I didn’t have a single number that could make me feel better.

LETTER DURING THE FEVER
Mama,
I did exactly what you asked me not to do.
I thought finding the others meant calling them only once I wasn’t afraid of their answer anymore.
I wanted to be the person who notices everything. I noticed, and I kept quiet.
If something happens to her, I won’t be able to write that I didn’t know.
I knew.
This time, I’m going to speak up before I’m ready.

CHAPTER TWELVE

The Road to the Clinic

February 15 to 18



SOUND FOUND AGAIN

*steady breathing under the quiet noise
of machines.*

The fuel could heat the cellar for several days or take Anastasiya to the clinic.

Mykola wrote the two choices on the blackboard. Nobody spoke. Under the blankets, some children were still asleep. The stove crackled as if it wanted to join the discussion.

“We don’t know if the road is open,” a man said.

“We don’t know how long she can wait either,” Vira answered.

“What if there’s nobody at the clinic?”

“There’s been a team there since last week,” Nina said.

“The convoy confirmed it.”

A woman pulled the blanket tighter around her two children.

“And the heat?”

Nobody dared to answer. Saving Anastasiya didn’t make everyone else’s cold go away.

I understood I couldn’t let Vira carry this decision too.

“I waited,” I said.

Every face turned toward me.

My voice was shaking. I would have preferred a bombing. Bombs don’t ask you to confess.

“She was coughing yesterday. Maybe before that. Her breathing changed. I didn’t say anything because I was scared they’d separate us. If we leave too late, it’s because of me.”

Vira opened her mouth.

“Don’t say it isn’t only my fault,” I added. “I know the war closed the roads and there isn’t enough fuel. But I was there. I saw. I want you to decide knowing the truth.”

The silence lasted a few seconds.

Olena Petrivna raised her hand, the way she would in class.

“We close off the back room. Everyone sleeps near the stove. We turn the heat down until they get back.”

Nina agreed. Then Mykola. The others followed, some right away, some after looking at their children.

Yuriy, the driver who had arrived the day before with supplies and an almost empty tank, volunteered.

“I know the road. We leave now.”

They poured the fuel into the vehicle. Ihor checked the battery. Nina got blankets ready. Vira gathered the medical papers. Everyone took a piece of the decision until it turned into a departure.

The drive took two hours.

Snow beat against the windshield. Vira held Anastasiya against her while I watched her face. I wanted to take her back, but my hands were shaking too much. So I held the flashlight whenever Yuriy had to steer around fallen branches. I could be useful without pretending to be the only useful one.

The clinic was in a low house near an old farm center. A nurse named Larysa brought us in right away. She watched Anastasiya breathe, measured what she needed to measure, and called a doctor from the next room.

The world filled up with movements I didn't recognize. They set up oxygen. They got treatments ready. Larysa explained what she was doing without asking me to understand every word.

"She's very tired," she said. "You were right to come."

Shame burned my face.

"We should have come sooner."

Larysa didn't hand me an automatic forgiveness.

"Now you're here. I need you to tell me exactly what she's had to drink and when the symptoms started."

I opened the notebook. My lists, which I'd thought were ridiculous an hour earlier, gave her the answers.

They let me stay near Anastasiya. I kept her warm when Larysa asked me to. I gave the times and the amounts. I didn't heal anybody. Medicine, the nurses and doctors, and the trip the cellar had made possible did that work.

The first night, I didn't sleep.

The second night, Vira made me lie down on a bench.

"If you wake me up too late..."

“I’ll wake you up too early, just for the pleasure of hearing you complain.”

When I opened my eyes again, daylight was coming through the window. Anastasiya was still breathing. Her chest moved more slowly. Between two breaths, there was finally a small silent space.

Larysa let me listen with a stethoscope. I didn’t understand the sound, but she smiled.

“She’s responding to treatment. We’ll keep going.”

I sat down on the floor and cried without making a sound.

We stayed two days. Anastasiya started drinking again. Her fever came down. Every improvement came in small amounts, without music and without miracles. A bottle finished a little better. A longer stretch of sleep. A breath that stopped running.

I used the notebook to write down the names of everyone who had gotten us there.



NAMES WRITTEN AT THE CLINIC
Mariya: milk, when Anastasiya didn't have a name yet.
The volunteer whose name I didn't catch: the first cans of formula.
Vira: the birth, the nights, the truth even when it hurts.
Ihor: a radio, a recorder carried in his bag, a necessary betrayal when he woke Vira.
Nina: the blankets and the spot near the stove.
Olena Petrivna: a raised hand with a solution.
Mykola: the blackboard, the fuel, the decision.
Yuriy: two hours of road on the way there, more on the way back.
Larysa and the clinic team: the care that made every breath a little less hard.
The children in the cellar: two nights with less heat.
Anastasiya: the enormous work of staying alive.

Before we left, Larysa closed my notebook.

"A list of thanks isn't a bill," she said.

"I want to remember what I owe."

"Then also write what you gave. Otherwise you'll turn every kind of help into a debt."

I didn't know what to add.

She took the pencil.

Katya: she told the truth in the end.

On the way back, Anastasiya slept against me. I didn't put my fingers under her nose every thirty seconds anymore. Only every five minutes. Vira decided that counted as progress.

The cellar welcomed us with weak heat, thin soup, and far too many questions. Pavlo had made a sign that said

WELCOME NASTIA in uneven letters. Nina gave me her own bowl before I could protest.

The next day, Ihor called me over to the south wall of the school.

A little white stem had pushed up through the frozen ground. The snowdrop was bent over, almost invisible against the dirty snow.

"It came up for her," Pavlo said behind us.

I shook my head.

"No. The flower doesn't know Anastasiya."

Pavlo looked disappointed.

I crouched down next to the stem.

"But it's here, and Anastasiya is breathing better. We can keep both things together without pretending one caused the other."

I opened the notebook to the charcoal pages.

| *Anastasiya is breathing better.*

| *A snowdrop came up by the wall.*

| *Neither one caused the other.*

| *I'm keeping them on the same page, and that's enough.*

PART THREE

Lost Voices



March to May

Chapters 13–18

CHAPTER THIRTEEN

The School Underground

March 11



SOUND RESTORED

chalk, then twenty voices reading without keeping the same rhythm.

In March, our improvised hour of class turned into two hours of school a day.

We were learning underneath the classrooms where lessons had stopped.

Above us, the classrooms still had their broken windows and their maps hanging crooked. In the cellar, Olena Petrivna had moved two tables, lined up three benches, and hung a blanket in front of the supplies. She had written the schedule on the blackboard that, only the day before, had been used for counting liters of water.

	9:00: reading.
	9:40: math.
	10:20: independent work.
	11:00: end of class. Earlier if the alert or lunch interrupts
	us.

"This is not a secret school," Olena Petrivna declared. "It's a school that happens to be missing permission, heat, notebooks, chairs, and probably good sense."

"So a normal school," Ihor said.

She handed him a piece of chalk.

"Since you're so clever, write the date."

Ihor wrote *March 11* with an eleven that leaned dangerously toward the next word. Pavlo corrected it without being asked. That's how class began.

I was planning to stay only ten minutes.

Anastasiya had eaten at 8:20. She was supposed to sleep until 9:30, unless she decided to change her own schedule. Nina had offered to watch her by the stove. I had gotten ready a bottle, two cloths, a blanket, a rag, a second blanket in case the first one suddenly stopped being enough, and a list of instructions.

"She likes to be carried on the left side," I explained.

"I have a left side," said Nina.

"You have to check that she isn't too warm."

"I've met warmth before."

"And if she cries for more than three minutes..."

Nina took the list.

"Go to class, Katya. If your sister does something no baby has ever done in the whole history of babies, I'll call you."

I sat in the back, in the spot where I could see the blanket that divided the classroom from the rest of the cellar.

Olena Petrivna handed out worksheets printed on the backs of old city notices. Mine had a water stain on the first question. We had to solve a system of two equations. I knew the method. I had even explained it to Alina before a test, back when our biggest problem was whether the teacher would let us use a calculator.

I got an impossible answer.

I started over.

I got another impossible answer, just a neater one.

Pavlo, who was sitting in front of me, raised his hand.

“Ma’am, if x equals negative seven, can the car still go forward?”

“Those aren’t kilometers, Pavlo.”

“Then why is there a car in the question?”

“So you’ll regret knowing how to read.”

The younger kids laughed. I crumpled the corner of my worksheet.

Olena Petrivna stopped next to my bench.

“You flipped the sign here.”

“I see it.”

“Redo that line.”

“I see it.”

“Katya.”

I would have liked her to congratulate me for coming back. I would have hated it if she congratulated me for coming back. What I wanted exactly kept changing every thirty seconds.

“Before, I wouldn’t have made that mistake.”

"Before, you made other ones."

"Not that one."

"How brave of you, to limit so precisely the mistakes you're allowed to make."

She put a fresh worksheet in front of me.

"Here, you aren't responsible for everybody's answers. Only your own. That's unpleasant enough."

I started over. The third answer was right.

Nobody clapped. Anastasiya didn't stop breathing. The ceiling didn't fall in. I felt a satisfaction so ordinary I almost cried over it.

During reading, Solomiya got stuck on the same word four times. On the fifth try, she shut her book.

"I can't do it."

"I couldn't either, a little while ago," I said.

She gave me a suspicious look.

"You're big."

"That's a rumor."

I crouched down beside her. We broke the word into syllables and tapped each one on the wood of the bench. Eventually the word came out. Solomiya read the whole sentence again, too fast this time, to erase the spot where she'd needed help.

I knew that method.

At 10:20, Olena Petrivna asked the kids to describe a place they wanted to get back to. The pencils didn't move.

"Which place do we have to pick?" Pavlo asked.

"Whichever you like."

"What if it doesn't exist anymore?"

Olena Petrivna took off her glasses, then put them back on. That bought her a few seconds whenever a question had no right answer.

“Then you can describe what used to be there.”

The pencils stayed just as still.

I thought about the gate at my school, the missing bell, the file of silence I recorded on the first day of school. I took out my phone. The battery said twenty-two percent. Enough for a few minutes.

“We could start with a sound,” I suggested.

Olena Petrivna turned toward me.

“Explain.”

“A whole place is too big. But a sound... You can pick the one that proves the place was really there.”

Pavlo raised his hand before I even finished.

“The bell on my dad’s bike. It was broken, so it rang every time he hit a bump.”

“That’s not how a bike bell is supposed to work,” said Ihor.

“My dad didn’t always work the way he was supposed to either.”

This time, even Olena Petrivna laughed.

Solomiya chose her aunt’s sewing machine. From the other side of the blanket, Nina called out that you could hear that machine three apartments away and it had probably helped get every window in the neighborhood shut.

A boy named Artem wanted to get back the sound of his dog running along a metal fence. A little girl chose her grandmother’s spoon tapping the edge of a pot. Another kid

said the school bus, then added: “The brakes, not the engine. The engine was boring.”

The voices started going around faster than the pencils.

I recorded the ones who wanted me to. For the others, I wrote it down. Some gave their first names. Others preferred a drawing with no name. Each time, I asked:

“Can I keep your sentence in my notebook?”

At first, they said yes before I’d even finished. So I changed the question.

“Do you want me to keep it, give it back to you, or copy it without your name?”



The answers started being different.

Pavlo wanted his full name and his age, “nine and almost ten for a long time now.” Solomiya only wanted a little bear

drawn in the corner. Artem wanted his page back so he could show it to his dog if he ever found him again.

When class was over, Nina handed me back a sleeping Anastasiya.

“She cried for one minute and forty seconds,” she announced. “I figured your rules still gave me one minute and twenty.”

I checked my sister’s face. She had a crease mark from the fabric on her cheek and one hand clamped around a button on Nina’s cardigan.

“See?” said Nina. “She used your absence to join another family.”

I felt the old fear rise. It didn’t have time to turn into a sentence.

“Then she has bad taste in clothes,” I answered.

Nina smiled and gently pried her button out of the little hand.

In the afternoon, I glued the pages the kids had allowed me to keep in after my own pages. The notebook got thicker on one side. It didn’t quite close anymore.

I had started this journal to talk to three men who were far away.

That day, it learned to listen to the children who were right here.

	THE SOUNDS WE WANT BACK
	Pavlo, nine and almost ten: the broken bell on his dad's bike.
	Solomiya, represented by a bear: a sewing machine behind a wall that was too thin.
	A voice with no name: a grandmother's spoon against the edge of a pot.
	Artem, page returned: a dog's claws against a fence.
	Two sisters who asked for the same line: their mother saying "get up" three times every morning.
	Katya: a school bell I pretended to hate back when I could still hear it.
	Anastasiya didn't pick anything. She chewed the corner of the page.
	I decided that meant: the sound of paper when you leave it some room.

CHAPTER FOURTEEN

The Roof With No Roof

March 30



SOUND REPAIRED

*the click of a recorder under a sky that
promises nothing.*

The loft in the barn had no roof left on its north side. Ihor claimed that improved the ventilation. I claimed that a missing wall or roof wasn't an architectural feature. He said I'd gotten very picky since we started living in a cellar.

We climbed up there when Vira was watching Anastasiya and the alerts stayed quiet. Old straw still covered the floor. A beam crossed the opening like the edge of a giant window. You could see the fields, the black trees, and farther off, the road we had come in on.

Ihor had spread the pieces of my recorder out on a piece of cloth.

"Don't lose anything," I said.

"Thanks. My original plan was to throw the screws in the straw."

"You already dropped one."

"It's inspecting the floor."

I found it next to his boot.

The recorder belonged to the school radio. I had borrowed it in August, with Mama's signature and a promise to return it after the competition. The war had turned the loan into a length of time the form hadn't planned for. During the evacuation, the cable had been crushed, and the record button only worked one time out of four.

Ihor was working with a wire he'd pulled out of a lamp and a tiny piece of metal he had straightened on the back of a spoon.

"Try it," he said.

I pressed the button.

A red dot appeared.

Neither of us said anything.

In the earbuds, I could hear the wind blowing through the opening, the rustle of Ihor's sleeve, and, very far away, a dog. The machine was recording the world again, without asking whether it was worth keeping.

"You fixed it."

"I know. I was hoping for a bigger reaction."

I threw my arms up.

"Ihor Bondarenko has connected two wires. Let the bells ring."

"There. That's better."

He lay back on the straw with his hands behind his head. Evening was coming down. A first star showed up above the

beam.

“That’s not a star,” he said. “It’s a planet.”

“You say that every time you don’t know its name.”

“It’s a scientific strategy.”

I sat against a post. For a few minutes, we argued about a constellation that looked like either a W or an M, depending only on which way you tilted your head. Ihor said my reasoning lacked rigor. He was lying upside down.

“Did you really want to build planes?” I asked.

He stopped joking.

“Little ones, first. Drones to watch for wildfires or bring medicine. After that, I don’t know.”

A distant noise rolled behind the hills. His eyes stayed on the sky.

“Now I hate everything that flies when I don’t know why it’s flying.”

I set the recorder down between us.

“I wanted to do the sound for movies. Not the pictures. Everything you only notice when it’s missing. Footsteps, doors, wind in a tree.”

“Do you still want to?”

I hadn’t thought about that verb being in the present.

“I think so.”

“Then you’d better keep the machine away from Anastasiya. She makes a lot of sounds, but she eats equipment.”

He sat up. His fingers found a twig in the straw and snapped it into equal pieces.

“The civilian network needs volunteers,” he said.

The sentence hadn’t changed volume. Still, every sound in the loft stepped back.

"What network?"

"The one that keeps up the relays between the villages. They haul batteries, fix cables, set up radio stations where the phones don't work anymore. Mykola knows the man in charge."

"Adults do that."

"There'll be adults."

"You're sixteen."

"You're fourteen, and you fill out medical records better than half the village."

"That's not an answer."

"No. It's the part where you hate having your own argument used against you."

I stood up. The beam kept me from pacing properly.

"You want to drive down roads that get hit, with batteries in a truck, and call it fixing radios."

"I want to go with a civilian team on roads they say are passable."

"Until they aren't."

"That's true here too."

"Why do you have to go?"

"Because I know how."

"You also know how to fix our stove. Stay and be useful here."

He dropped the bits of twig.

"You don't get to draw a circle around people and call it protecting them."

The sentence hit me exactly where he knew it would.

"And you don't get to play hero because you're scared of sitting still."

“I’m not playing.”

“Everybody I love finds a very important reason to leave. Papa is repairing a line. Maksym is treating the wounded. Bohdan is repairing communications. Now you. You pick useful verbs and disappear behind them.”

Ihor stood up too.

“I’m not your father or your brothers.”

“I know.”

“Then don’t punish me for them being gone.”

I wanted to answer. The sky rumbled again, farther away this time. We waited for another sound, not knowing how far away it was. It didn’t come.

“I’m scared of being useless,” Ihor said. “And I’m scared of going. Both are true.”

He wasn’t looking at the sky anymore. He was looking at me.

“I think about the road in the snow,” he went on. “I think about the clinic. Every time a radio works, somebody can ask for fuel, a doctor, or a spot in a convoy. I know how to fix that. Not every time. Not alone. But I know how.”

My anger still had arguments. It didn’t have an easy target anymore.

“I’m scared you won’t come back,” I said.

He nodded.

“Me too.”

I hated his answer because it didn’t give me anything to fight.

“Promise you won’t leave this week.”

“They’re not leaving this week.”

“Promise you’ll stay away from all danger.”

"I can't."

"At least promise..."

I stopped. Our family had been full of impossible promises. *I'll be home soon. Everything's fine. We just have to wait. Tomorrow will be quieter.* They had helped us sleep and taught us to lie.

Ihor pushed the recorder toward me.

"I can promise to follow the adults, to stay away from military areas, and to say when I'm scared."

"Even if it makes you look like a coward?"

"Especially if it makes me look like a coward."

"I can promise not to say I'm fine when I'm not."

"Even if you want to stop me from going?"

"I didn't promise to become pleasant."

"Good. I wouldn't recognize you."

The red dot was still blinking on the recorder.

"It got everything," I said.

"Delete it."

My finger hovered over the button.

"No."

"My voice sounds horrible."

"That's proof it's authentic."

I put my finger back on the button.

"Seriously, do you want me to delete it?"

Ihor thought about it.

"You can keep it. But ask me before you play it for anyone else."

"Okay."

We listened to the last few seconds. You could hear the wind, our argument chopped into pieces, and then two

voices saying, almost together, that they were scared.

Ihor sat down next to me. His shoulder touched mine. Neither of us moved.

Above the missing roof, the constellation was still a W from my side and an M from his.

We didn't try to make it agree with itself.

PROMISES WE DIDN'T MAKE
I'll never leave.
Nothing will happen to me.
I'll always be able to send a message.
I won't be scared.
You won't be mad at me.

THE PROMISE WE RECORDED
We won't say "everything's fine" just to make the other one stop talking.
The wind almost covers our voices. They're there anyway.



CHAPTER FIFTEEN

The First Laugh

April 7



SOUND SAVED

seven seconds that no war can make any
less true.

The wooden bird fell at 9:13.

I know the time because I had just finished giving Anastasiya her bottle and had written the amount in my notebook. Ihor was trying to shorten the string above her basket. He was holding the bird with one hand and pulling at the knot with the other.

“You should take the toy down before you fix it,” I said.

“You should trust the professionals.”

The string snapped.

The bird bounced off the blanket, hit the edge of the basket, and landed on its back with its short wing pointing at the ceiling.

Ihor looked at it.

“Planned landing.”

Anastasiya laughed.

It wasn't the little puff she sometimes made in her sleep. It wasn't a smile that happened to come with a sound. Her belly tightened, her mouth opened, and a clear laugh came out of her, as if she had just gotten a very old joke about boys who can't tie knots.

Everybody went quiet.

Even the stove seemed to be waiting.

"Did she just..." Nina began.

"Shh," six of us answered at once.

Ihor picked up the bird and dropped it again.

Anastasiya blinked.

He dropped it a third time.

She yawned.

"You lost your audience," I said.

"Great artists are always misunderstood."

Pavlo started waving a spoon around. Solomiya did a goat, probably the one from Vira's story. Mykola hid his face behind a dish towel and then whipped it away with a shout. The whole cellar turned into a terrible and very determined show.

Anastasiya watched us with the worried look of someone surrounded by grownups who had suddenly lost their minds.

I had the recorder in my bag.

I took it out, checked the battery, and pressed the red button.

"Everybody stop," I said.

Nobody listened to me.

Ihor picked up the bird again. Instead of dropping it, he set it on his head. The short wing slid down in front of his eye.

“Look,” he told Anastasiya. “This is the Director of Landings.”

The bird fell off all by itself.

Anastasiya laughed a second time.



Seven seconds.

I watched the sound line shake on the little screen. I waited until it was completely over before I stopped recording. Then I made two copies, one on my phone and one on the memory card. Bohdan taught me that keeping only one copy of a file is a technical way of planning a regret.

“Play it,” Pavlo begged.

We crowded around the machine. The recorded laugh was smaller than the real one. You could hear a spoon falling, Ihor talking, and Nina holding her breath. But it was there.

Vira sat down without a word. She had one hand over her mouth.

“Are you crying?” Ihor asked.

“The smoke.”

“The stove is on the other side.”

“Very mobile smoke.”

She wiped her eyes and ordered us to make something to celebrate. Our supplies didn't stretch to a cake. Nina thinned the soup with water so everyone could have an extra ladleful. Mykola found a jar with three spoonfuls of jam in it, jam so old that nobody remembered whose it was. Olena Petrivna declared that after several months without an owner, it counted as a donation to education.

Vira started an old lullaby. She pitched it too low and got trapped on a note nobody else could reach. Ihor tried to drag the melody back up. Nina came in late. The kids only knew the ending.

Anastasiya didn't laugh again, but she patted both hands against the blanket, as if our concert deserved some effort anyway.

At 7:42 in the evening, my phone buzzed.

The network had been coming and going since morning. Sometimes messages piled up for days before they made it through the relays. This one only showed a number, no saved name. I almost didn't open it.

The voice note was eleven seconds long.

A breath. A rustle. Then three knocks against a microphone.

| *Knock. Knock. Knock.*

I dropped my spoon.

“Bohdan,” I said.

Everyone crowded closer, but Vira raised a hand.

“Give her some air.”

I played the file again.

After the three knocks, my brother’s voice came through in pieces.

“Little Magpie... safe for now... no news from Papa... don’t believe Maksym if he says... favorite...”

The end vanished into a metallic noise. There was no place, no date, no certainty that a reply would reach him. Only proof that Bohdan had been breathing long enough to talk when he sent it.

I listened to the eleven seconds eleven times.

Ihor sat down next to me.

“What are you going to send him?”

I started putting together a report in my head. Anastasiya getting sick. The clinic. The fuel. The civilian network. The supplies. The cold nights. Everything that would prove I had stayed on watch while he was gone.

Then I looked at my sister.

She was trying to grab the repaired bird. Her fist kept closing a few centimeters too soon.

I attached the file of the laugh.

I added only one sentence.

| *This is Anastasiya. She thinks Ihor is ridiculous. So do we.*

I knocked three times on the phone and sent the message before the network could disappear.

The little circle stayed stuck for a long time. At 8:06, it finally said sent.

For a few minutes, I was happy.

I didn't think about Papa still being missing. I didn't count how long it had been since we heard Maksym's voice. I didn't make this joy pay for the right to come in.

It was small, incomplete, and whole.

Like the recorded laugh.

	FILE 04-07 NASTIA LAUGH TWO
	<i>Length of the laugh: seven seconds. Before it, a spoon falls, Ihor says a sentence he denies ever saying, and the bird falls off his head.</i>
	<i>Copies: memory card, phone, and a message sent to Bohdan somewhere behind the silence.</i>
	<i>This file doesn't prove we're okay. It proves this moment happened.</i>

CHAPTER SIXTEEN

No More Messages

April 18 to May 4



SOUND LOST

the little buzz that sent everyone running to a phone.

The relays stopped answering on a Friday morning.

Nobody in Lypove saw the strikes. We heard several rumbles to the east, and then the phones lost their bars one by one. My screen said *emergency calls only*, and after that, nothing.

At first, everyone kept up their usual habits. Holding the phone up near the basement window. Walking over to the south wall. Turning it off, counting to ten, turning it back on, as if our patience could intimidate the network.

At noon, Mykola came back from the village office.

“Two relays are down. Maybe three. The civilian team leaves tomorrow.”

I looked at Ihor.

He didn’t look away.

"They said I can go with them," he said.

Vira set down her ladle.

"Who's in charge?"

"Oleksiy Hryhorovych. There'll be four adults and two vehicles. We're taking batteries to the first site. If the road is closed, we come back."

"You don't go near any military sites."

"No."

"You don't leave the man in charge to prove you can run faster."

"No."

"You wear your helmet."

"Even if it ruins my hair."

Vira raised the ladle.

"I can still stop you from leaving with this thing."

Ihor stopped smiling.

"I'll follow the rules, Babusia."

She nodded and went back to the soup. Her hand was shaking enough to knock against the side of the pot.

All day, I didn't ask Ihor anything. I helped him check the cables, count the batteries, and wrap the network's transmitter in a dry cloth. We talked about objects, because objects had simple answers.

"Four adapters?"

"Four."

"Two flashlights?"

"Three."

"You only wrote down two."

"The third one's in my pocket."

"Then it has to be on the list too."

"I knew you'd find a way to be in charge of me leaving."

At dusk, I handed him a page torn out of the back of the notebook.

I had drawn three black dots on it.

Under the dots, I had written: *I'm here.*

"If you find an open line and you can't talk," I said.

"I knock three times."

"Don't use the code to say everything's fine if it isn't."

"We have a recorded promise."

"I know."

He folded the page in four and slid it into the inside pocket of his jacket.

"I'm scared," he said.

The truth made his face look younger.

"Me too."

We didn't say anything else.

The next day, the vehicles left before sunrise. Vira checked the zipper on Ihor's jacket twice. He let her. As he was climbing in, he handed me the wooden bird.

"Keep the Director of Accidents."

"He's as badly built as you are."

"That's why you two will get along."

I could have told him not to go. I could have turned my last words into a punishment, so he'd carry off my anger instead of my fear.

"Come back when you can," I said.

"Yes."

He didn't say soon.

The two vehicles disappeared behind the trees.

The first day, I kept the radio next to me. The second day, I set it against the wall during class. The third day, I carried it over near the stove, convinced the heat would improve the reception. Ihor would have made fun of that theory. His being gone made all my ideas harder to correct.

Every evening, I marked the date in charcoal on the side of a shelf.

April 19.

April 20. Easter.

April 21.

At the fourth mark, Anastasiya reached out and grabbed the charcoal. She crushed it in her palm, then pressed her black fingers against the wood. Five short smudges appeared next to my dates.

"You're counting wrong," I told her.

She tried to put the charcoal in her mouth.

I took it away from her. She screamed with an outrage that proved that, in her mind, I had just committed a robbery.

On Easter, Nina had made a *paska* without butter, closer to bread than to cake. Vira had prayed quietly for three men and a boy. When Mykola said, "Christ is risen!" we answered, "He is risen indeed!" not as loudly as usual, but all together.

In the days that followed, rumors took the place of messages. A driver had seen the team near the first relay. A woman claimed the road was cut. Somebody else said a transmitter was working again in a village to the south. Every piece of news came with no name, no time, and no way to trace it back to where it started.

I wrote them down, then crossed them out.

Olena Petrivna found me in front of the shelf with the charcoal.

"You'll run out of wood before you run out of days," she said.

"I want to know how long they've been gone."

"Your notebook knows the date."

"It's not the same."

She didn't ask why.

I looked at the marks as soon as I woke up. I saw them during meals, during class, during conversations. They weren't measuring time anymore. They were manufacturing it. Every new mark added a whole day to what I was afraid of.

I took a wet rag.

The charcoal smeared before it disappeared. The dates turned into a gray blur. Anastasiya's fingerprints lasted longer than my numbers.

I didn't stop waiting. I only stopped building a fence out of the days.

During the next class, I asked the kids to close their eyes for one minute. The exercise came from my old sound project. Before, I would have asked them to write down everything they heard. This time, I asked them to describe what was missing.

Their answers were more precise than mine.

Pavlo said, "Ihor's cough when he swallows too fast."

Solomiya said, "Vira doesn't yell *put away your wires* anymore."

From the kitchen, Nina added, "And nobody tells me my radio isn't tuned right."

Vira didn't say anything.

That evening, I found her sitting next to the radio. She was holding the dial between two fingers and slowly turning through the frequencies. Static. A whistle. A foreign voice, lost right away. Static again.

"You should sleep," she told me.

"So should you."

"I'm sixty-six. At my age, you don't sleep anymore. You wait for morning with your eyes closed."

I sat down beside her.

We listened to the white noise for a long time.

It didn't bring any message.

But at least it kept us from pretending that silence doesn't make a sound.

INVENTORY OF SILENCES
The silence of the phone: a screen you keep turning back on, even after you've stopped believing in it.
The silence of the radio: static that sounds like a sea without water.
Vira's silence: a ladle that hits the side of the pot too often.
Ihor's silence: nobody contradicting my bad theories.
Bohdan's silence: three knocks my mind sometimes adds in the middle of the white noise.
Papa's silence: the oldest one. It knows how to take up all the room without moving at all.
Maksym's silence: a joke we're still waiting for the end of.
My silence: not as solid as before. I said out loud that I was scared.

CHAPTER SEVENTEEN

The Red Envelope

May 12



SOUND BROKEN

*an official letter unfolded on a school
table.*

The official arrived during dictation.

He was wearing a coat too warm for May and holding a briefcase against his body. Mykola brought him down into the cellar. They talked near the stairs, quietly enough to get everyone's attention.

When Mykola turned toward me, I understood that the briefcase had our name in it.

First I thought of Ihor.

Vira stood up so fast her chair tipped over. The official looked at his list.

"Kateryna Kovalchuk?"

My relief came instantly, and it was shameful. It wasn't Ihor.

Then I thought of Papa, Maksym, and Bohdan, in that order, as if the order could decide which of the three had been hit.

“That’s me.”

The man took out a thick envelope. Two red stamps overlapped on the flap. He asked whether an adult from my family was present.

“Baba Vira is the adult responsible for them,” Mykola said.

I didn’t correct him. My hands were already reaching out.

The official gave the envelope to Vira.

“It has my name on it,” I said.

“The procedure requires...”

“It has my name on it.”

Vira took the envelope, then gave it to me without opening it.

The paper resisted. I had to slide a finger under the glue and run it all the way to the edge. A sheet folded in three fell onto the table.

The text used words that seemed chosen so that no person would have to speak.

| Kovalchuk, Maksym Petrovych.

| Seriously wounded in service.

| Transferred for surgery and care.

| Facility not disclosed at this time.

I read the last sentence four times.

“Where is he?”

The official lowered his eyes to his list.

"We don't have that information."

"Who does?"

"The coordination center might be able to... once communications..."

"Is he alive?"

He looked at Vira.

"The notice says he was transferred alive. I can't confirm anything more."

| *Transferred alive.*

Two words wide enough to hold every possible wound and not precise enough to hold my brother.

"And Petro Kovalchuk?" Vira asked.

The man turned a page.

"No update."

"Bohdan?"

"Nothing in this file."

He said he was sorry. He probably meant it. Then he asked Vira for a signature proving the letter had been delivered.

At the evacuation point, I had resented Vira for being able to sign for me. This time, I would have given anything for an adult's signature to be enough to carry the news.

Vira's name trembled at the bottom of the page.

After he left, nobody went back to the dictation. Olena Petrivna erased the blackboard even though it hadn't done anything wrong. Nina set a cup in front of me. I pushed it away. Pavlo led the little ones to the other side of the blanket.

Vira sat down on my left.

"Say something," I asked her.

"I don't know what to say."

"You always find something."

"Not today."

I wanted her to lie to me. I wanted her to announce that hospitals hid their addresses to protect the wounded, that no details was good news, that Maksym was already joking with a nurse about a can opener.

She didn't make anything up.

I took my notebook and went upstairs to a room on the ground floor. Part of the window was covered with a board. The sun came through a crack and cut the floor in two.

I wrote to God.

The first words were too polite. I crossed them out.

The next ones sounded like a prayer somebody else had learned. I crossed those out too.

So I wrote what I really thought.

When I finished, the page scared me. I tore it out. The sound cut across the room as sharp as ripping cloth.

I tore the sheet in half, then in quarters. I set the pieces next to the little cold stove. There was a box of matches left on the shelf.

My hand closed around it.

Vira came in.

She didn't take the box. She didn't pick up the pieces.

"If you tell me God has a plan, I'll break the last window," I said.

"It's already cracked. Your gesture wouldn't have much effect."

“Vira.”

She sat down against the wall.

“I don’t know his plan. I’m not his lawyer.”

“Then what are your prayers for?”

She thought long enough that I knew she wasn’t preparing a lesson.

“Sometimes, to keep fear from being the only voice in the room. Sometimes, for nothing I can measure.”

“Mama prayed.”

“Yes.”

“She died.”

“Yes.”

“I prayed for Maksym.”

“I know.”

“You could at least try to defend what you believe.”

Vira looked at the four pieces on the floor.

“I believe you have the right to be angry. If God can’t handle an angry teenager, then he’s less sturdy than they taught me.”

I didn’t strike the match.

We stayed there until Anastasiya started crying in the cellar. Her screams came up the stairs. I didn’t get up right away. Neither did Vira.

A few minutes later, Nina brought the baby up.

“She won’t have anybody,” she said.

“She learns fast,” I answered.

Nina set Anastasiya on the blanket next to me. My sister had been holding her head up on her own for weeks, and she pushed herself up on her forearms. She aimed for forbidden objects more precisely than she did anything else.

She spotted the nearest scrap of paper.

Before I could grab it, she rolled onto her side, stretched out her arm, and closed her hand around the page. She crumpled it with great satisfaction.

“Even she hates my prayer,” I said.

Vira got the paper back before it reached Anastasiya’s mouth.

“She hates flat documents. It’s an opinion about the format.”

I laughed once. The sound made me angry. Then it passed.

We spread the four pieces out on the table. A corner was missing, gone soggy in the baby’s hand. I used tape from the medical bag. The strips cut across my sentences. Some of the letters didn’t quite meet anymore.

I didn’t copy the page over neatly.

I glued it into the notebook, cracks and all.

LETTER TO GOD, TAPED BACK TOGETHER
God,
I'm not asking you to give Mama back anymore. Even I know prayers don't turn back time.
I'm asking you for an address.
Where is Maksym? Who is giving him water? Is he making jokes so nobody sees he's scared? Is anybody answering them, even if they're bad?
Where is Papa? Is he still repairing a line, or do we keep repeating that sentence because we can't stand any other?
Why did Bohdan get eleven seconds and then nothing?
I don't want to hear that we're strong. People say that when they're about to leave without giving us what we need.
I don't want a sign. I won't take a flower, a ray of sunshine, or Anastasiya's first tooth as an answer instead of my brothers.
I want names, a place, a voice. I want to be able to call someone and hear them pick up.
If you're there, don't turn my silence into patience. I'm not patient. I'm furious.
Katya.

The tape cuts the word *furious* in half.

You can still read it.

CHAPTER EIGHTEEN

The Register of the Living

May 28



SOUND KEPT

*several voices around one page that
doesn't ask anyone to speak alone.*

The families from the next village arrived with dust on their shoes and incomplete lists.

A strike had hit several houses the day before. The village convoy had brought the survivors to Lypove because our school had a cellar, a water point, and a few square meters we still pretended we could share.

The classroom became a reception center. Olena Petrivna put the worksheets away. Mykola wrote the arrivals on the blackboard. Nina handed out weak tea. Vira examined the injured with a nurse from the convoy. The children stayed by the wall, as quiet as if they'd been told not to take up any more space.

A little girl was wearing a green coat far too big for her. She held the end of the sleeve in her fist to keep her hand

from disappearing.

“You’re the one who writes down sounds,” she told me.

I didn’t know how she knew. Children pass along information faster than all of Ihor’s relays.

“Sometimes.”

“Write my brother.”

I opened the notebook.

“What’s his name?”

“Mykhailo.”

“And your name?”

“Daryna.”

“Where is Mykhailo?”

She shrugged. An adult behind her said he hadn’t been found after the evacuation. I wrote Mykhailo, *missing*, then asked how old he was.

Daryna read over my hand.

“That’s not enough.”

“Tell me what I should add.”

“He hates beets. Even when Mama cuts them really small, he finds them. And he wants to be a goalkeeper, but he closes his eyes when the ball comes.”

She thought about it.

“Write that he cheats at cards.”

“Is that important?”

“Yes. Otherwise they might look for the wrong one.”

I added every detail.

A boy sitting next to her came closer. His mother had died during the night. He didn’t want me to write how.

“She smelled like apples,” he said. “Not apple perfume. Real ones, in my grandpa’s cellar.”



I wrote that sentence without his name, because he asked me to.

Then other children came.

At first, I had drawn three columns: *dead*, *wounded*, *missing*. They looked like the official's list. Categories too neat for lives that weren't.

I turned the page.

At the top, I wrote:

REGISTER OF THE LIVING

"But my mom is dead," said the apple boy.

"She lived," I answered. "You can tell me what you want to keep of her."

He put a finger on the page.

"Then also write that she sang the last word of a song before it came. It drove everybody crazy."

The register filled up all day.

I asked each person what they would let me write down. Their full name, just their first name, or no name. A sentence they dictated, a sentence in their own handwriting, a drawing. They could come back, correct it, cross it out, or take their page back. I didn't know yet that those questions would help me later in front of a camera. I only knew how it felt when adults decided for me what my story meant.

Pavlo demanded an entry even though he wasn't dead, wounded, or missing.

"It says *living*," he pointed out. "I qualify."

He wrote that he could stand on one foot for forty-two seconds, but only the left one. Olena Petrivna timed him. He fell at twenty-six.

"The floor moved," he announced.

"Do you want me to write down the lie too?" I asked.

"Write *disputed record*."

Solomiya drew the bear from the book with an enormous pot and only three grains of salt. Under the drawing, she wrote by herself: *Now I can read catastrophe without help*. She had left out a letter, then added it above the word with an arrow.

At first, Nina refused.

"I'm right here. Everybody knows me."

"Exactly," I said. "What do you want people to know, instead of just remembering your blankets?"

She took the pencil.

Nina sings out of tune on purpose because songs that are too perfect make people too confident.

Mykola wrote that he hadn't fallen in the snow, he had been testing the depth of the ditch. Uncle Serhiy, our neighbor from the building, who had come to Lypove with a February convoy, added underneath: *Result of the test: cold*.

Olena Petrivna wrote that she hated correcting in red pen and did it anyway, because the other colors always faded. She wanted to see a classroom again where the loudest noise would be a student slamming a textbook shut too hard.

Vira pushed the notebook away.

"I don't have anything interesting."

"You kept a sugar cube for three months."

"And I wasted it on a dangerous dessert."

“You tell a story about a goat that won’t go back into the barn. Anastasiya smiled at it.”

“That goat has existed since before I was born. She doesn’t need publicity.”

I wrote: *Vira Bondarenko: permission pending.*

She tried to take the pencil. I closed the notebook.

“Nobody changes the register without the author’s permission.”

“What author?”

“Me.”

“There, you see, school is putting bad ideas in her head again,” she said to Olena Petrivna.

But she was smiling. I opened the notebook again and put the pencil beside her.

“You decide what happens to your page.”

Vira looked at the line, then pushed the pencil away.

“Leave it pending.”

That evening, Daryna came back. No news of Mykhailo had come. She sat down next to me and reread her entry.

“You forgot that he snores.”

I added: *He denies that he snores.*

“That’s better.”

She leaned her head against my arm. I held still until she sat up on her own.

At the back of the cellar, Ihor’s spot was still empty. I wanted to write that he fixed things before he’d admit they were broken, that he was afraid of being useless, and that his recorded voice told the truth even under the wind.

I didn’t write for him.

I left a blank page and wrote only in the margin: *Saved until he comes back.*

For Maksym, I wrote in pencil, lightly enough to be able to change it: *Tells bad stories; we listen to the end to hear if his voice is shaking. Was transferred alive. The rest is missing.*

For Bohdan: *Calls his sister Little Magpie. Three knocks mean I'm here. Last proof: eleven seconds.*

For Papa, my hand stopped.

In the end, I wrote: *Petro Kovalchuk fixes what other people think can't be fixed. His faucet has been dripping for four years.*

Both sentences could be true at the same time.

Anastasiya woke up while I was working. I set her on my lap. She slapped the page with her palm, then made a string of serious sounds that sounded like a speech in a language only she knew the rules of.

"What should I put for you?" I asked.

She grabbed the pencil.

A black line shot across the bottom of the page.

I left it.

When Anastasiya fell asleep again, I started a new section.

TO THOSE IN CHARGE

I wrote:

You get numbers. The number of people displaced. The number of houses destroyed. The number of days without electricity.

Here is what numbers can't say: Mykhailo hates beets and shuts his eyes when the ball comes. A woman who died smelled like apples and always sang too early. Pavlo makes up rules when he loses his balance. Nina sings out of tune on purpose. My brother tells terrible jokes, and nobody can give me the address of his hospital bed.

When you decide how long a war can last, how many roads can close, and how many children can wait...

I stopped.

The last sentence wouldn't come. Every one I tried sounded like a speech given by an adult in front of a flag. I wasn't an adult. I was a girl in a cellar with a sleeping baby against her and a notebook that had gotten too thick to close.

I didn't force the ending.

I left several lines empty.

Around me, people were still talking in low voices. They were correcting their entries, arguing over a memory, asking for a page. The voices overlapped without canceling each other out.

The notebook wasn't only the place where I held on to my own family anymore.

It had become a place where anyone could say: here is what you have no right to erase.

FIRST ENTRIES IN THE REGISTER OF THE LIVING
Daryna: wears a green coat that's too big and refuses to let her brother be summed up by the word missing.
Mykhailo: hates beets, cheats at cards, wants to be a goalkeeper, and shuts his eyes when the ball comes. Snores, whatever he says.
A mother with no name: smelled like apples and always sang the last word too soon.
Pavlo: disputed record, left foot.
Solomiya: can write catastrophe, even if not all the letters arrive at the same time.
Nina: sings out of tune on purpose, according to Nina.
Vira: permission still pending.
Ihor: page saved.
Katya: asks questions before she writes. Still learning to listen to the answers.
Anastasiya: a black line running off the margin.

The register starts here.
It isn't finished.

PART FOUR

What the World Hears



June, then September

Chapters 19–24

CHAPTER NINETEEN

Three Knocks on the Radio

June 3



SOUND FOUND AGAIN

three knocks behind the static.

Vira woke me up by putting a hand over my mouth. For a second, I thought the alert had started. I reached for Anastasiya before I even opened my eyes. She was asleep in her basket, one arm flung up over her head. The cellar was dark, except near the table, where the radio made a small green rectangle.

Vira took her hand away.

“Listen.”

The radio was spitting static. A voice appeared, warped, and disappeared behind a whistle. Mykola was holding the antenna against the wall. Nina was standing with a blanket around her shoulders. Everyone who wasn’t still asleep had come closer without making a sound.

I thought of Ihor.

Then three knocks came through the static.

Not three identical sounds. The first was sharp, the second fainter, the third almost swallowed by the frequency.

My body recognized them before my head did.

I'm here.

"Bohdan," I said.

The voice came back.

"...ittle Magpie... can you hear me?"

I snatched the handset out of Mykola's hands.

"Bohdan?"

"Three knocks... if yes."

I knocked on the edge of the table three times with my fingernail. The sound rang into the open mic.

Very far away, someone burst out laughing. Even mangled by the radio, I knew it was his. Bohdan always laughed a second too late, as if he were checking first whether the joke deserved the effort.

"You're alive," I said.

"That's my diagnosis too."

"Where are you?"

"I can't give... location. They keep moving us. I got your message. The baby's laugh."

Anastasiya stirred in her basket. I held my breath, afraid her waking up would use up the seconds we had left.

"Maksym?"

The crackling swelled. I thought the connection was already gone.

"Surgery's done," Bohdan said. "He's alive. Care center. He says... tell Katya... can opener... rematch."

I started crying because of a can opener.

“Can he talk?”

“He complains. So yes.”

“Give me his address.”

“I don’t have it. I swear. The wounded get transferred... I’m looking.”

“Papa?”

This time, the silence between us didn’t come from the radio.

“Nothing certain,” Bohdan answered. “Katya, I’m not going to make anything up.”

I closed my eyes.

He had learned our new rule.

“Okay.”

“I have to go.”

“No. Wait. Tell me something nobody else knows.”

“What?”

“So I can be sure it’s you.”

Vira turned toward me. I knew the question was absurd. I also knew that as soon as the voice disappeared, my mind would try to convince me I had made it up.

Bohdan answered without thinking.

“You broke Papa’s blue mug when you were nine. You hid the pieces in the flour jar and gave me your candy for two weeks so I’d keep quiet.”

“Three weeks.”

“The last two payments were late.”

I laughed and cried at the same time, which makes a very ugly sound and makes breathing almost impossible.

“Bohdan...”

"I'm here, Little Magpie."

The frequency crackled.

"Bohdan?"

"Three knocks," he said again.

Then there was only static.

I kept the handset against my mouth.

"I'm here too," I said after he was gone.

Nobody tried to take it away from me.

The engine arrived an hour before dawn.

We heard it sputtering from the road, then voices in the yard. Vira ran for the stairs. She had forgotten her blanket and her slippers. I followed her with Anastasiya under my cardigan.

The first man out of the vehicle was carrying a coil of cable. The second had a bandaged cheek. Ihor jumped down from the back with his tool bag and almost fell because one of his legs had gone numb.

Vira slapped him.

Not hard. Just enough to make everyone stop.

Then she pulled him into a hug.

"You stink of fuel," she said into his shoulder.

"Hi, Baba."

"And you're skinny."

"We just fixed two relays."

"That doesn't have any calories."

When she finally let go, Ihor turned to me.

I had prepared several sentences while he was gone. None of them were available anymore.

He looked at Anastasiya, then at my face.

"Are you okay?"

I hated the question. It was too small for all the days he'd missed.

"You didn't send a single message."

"No."

"Not one word."

"The first relay had lost its power. The second had its antenna on the ground. The road home was cut off behind us on the second day. We couldn't send anything until tonight."

I wanted to keep being angry at him. His explanation took away a wall I could push against.

"I thought you were dead," I said.

"So did I, twice."

Vira gave him a look.

"That isn't a useful joke," she said.

"It wasn't a joke."

He didn't add anything. The truth was already awkward enough to carry.

I punched his arm with my fist closed. He didn't step back. Then I rested my forehead against his jacket for two seconds, maybe three. The cloth smelled of smoke, metal, and several nights without soap.

"Don't ever tell anyone about that," I whispered.

"I'll say you were checking how strong my zipper was."

"It's terrible."

"I noticed."

Anastasiya woke up between us. She stared at Ihor as if he had to justify his absence in front of a court of babies, then grabbed the pull on his zipper.

"She remembers me," he said.

"She's trying to eat your zipper. Don't read too much into everything."

Down in the cellar, the team explained that the relays would stay fragile. One was running on a salvaged battery. The other could only transmit in short bursts. Important communications would go first: emergencies, medical care, evacuations, lists of people being searched for.

Ihor had slipped our family name onto a list during a test. Somebody had found a unit near Bohdan's. That night's connection had been pieced together by five operators, two repaired relays, and a stroke of luck that none of them wanted to count as a method.

"So you can't call him back?" I asked.

"Not now."

I made myself not hear *never again* inside those two words.

The team leader announced that a humanitarian convoy would probably arrive on June 5. It would bring medicine, equipment for the water point, and batteries. Journalists were traveling with it to document what the villages that had been cut off needed.

At that word, several people looked at my notebook.

I pulled it closer against me.

"No."

"Nobody asked you anything," said Olena Petrivna.

"Your eyes just did."

Pavlo looked away with a total lack of subtlety.

Later, Ihor came out to find me in the yard. The morning light made the damage less frightening and more exact. A tile was missing above the entrance. The wall still had a

dark stain left by the winter. Weeds were growing between the cracks in the concrete.

“You don’t have to show the notebook,” he said.

“I know.”

“Or your face.”

“I know.”

“Or Anastasiya.”

“I know, Ihor.”

He picked up a nut near his shoe.

“On the road, a man with a radio asked us to record our arrival. I said no, because one of the villages needed to stay hard to locate. He put his equipment away.”

“And?”

“Speaking and being exposed aren’t the same thing. You can say yes to one and no to the other.”

“Since when are you an expert on journalists?”

“For about twelve seconds.”

He rolled the nut between his fingers.

“But I’m serious.”

I knew he was.

I opened the notebook to Bohdan’s page and added in pencil: *Voice found again on June 3. Alive. Unbearable about old debts.*

For Maksym, I crossed out *The rest is missing*, then wrote: *Survived surgery. Still complaining.*

Papa’s line stayed the way it was.

Good news hadn’t filled every empty space. It had only switched on a small lamp in the middle of them.

For that night, it was enough.

	WHAT THREE KNOCKS SAID
	Bohdan is alive.
	Maksym is alive.
	Papa is still missing.
	Ihor came back with both ears, a bad zipper, and no invented excuses.
	I thought good news was supposed to chase fear away. Actually, they can sit on the same bench without talking to each other.
	I slept forty minutes.
	That was a lot.

CHAPTER TWENTY

The Festival of Sounds Found Again

June 5, before the alert



SOUND KEPT

*a pot that refuses to become a quiet
instrument.*

The idea for the festival came from Pavlo, which should have warned us.

The convoy was supposed to arrive before noon. Mykola wanted to clean up the yard, Olena Petrivna wanted to post the school's needs, and Nina wanted to keep anyone from touching the soup before the visitors got there.

Pavlo wanted to put on a show.

"They're going to film the holes in the walls," he said. "The holes can't do anything."

"Neither can you, but that's never stopped you from performing," I answered.

He took that as a yes.

By nine o'clock, a sign was taped to the classroom door:

FESTIVAL OF SOUNDS FOUND AGAIN

Underneath, Solomiya had drawn an ear so big it looked like a cabbage.

Everyone had to bring a sound they wanted to hear again. Not a speech. Not a story about what we'd lost. An ordinary sound, forgotten, or impossible to make in the cellar.

"Does a real cake make a sound?" Pavlo asked.

"Yes," Nina answered. "It makes the sound of people who stop complaining while they eat."

We set up three benches in the yard. Ihor stretched a blanket between two posts to hide the most damaged wall. Vira made him do it over because the cloth was sagging.

"The visitors are coming to hand out medicine, not to inspect a stage," he protested.

"Then why did you tie that side like a man being chased by a goat?"

"I've never been chased by a goat."

"That explains your knot."

I set the repaired recorder on a crate turned upside down. Before I pressed the red button, I asked:

"Who's okay with their voice being kept?"

Almost every hand went up. Daryna kept hers tucked against her green coat.

"You can take part without being recorded," I told her.

She thought about it, then sat down next to the machine.

"You can take the sound. Not my name."

I wrote the rule on a scrap of paper and put it under the mic.

Pavlo went first. He had found an old deflated ball among the things that came with the families from the next village, and he kicked it against the wall with his left foot.

The ball made a soft thud, then rolled into the tub of soapy water.

“That was the sound of a goal,” he announced.

“That was the sound of a wet sock,” said Solomiya.

“The field was difficult.”

Daryna stood up. She put both hands in front of her face, then pulled them apart at the last second while Pavlo tossed the ball gently to her.

“My brother closes his eyes like that when he’s in goal,” she explained.

She caught the ball against her stomach.

“But sometimes he stops it anyway.”

We still had no news of Mykhailo. His absence stayed there on the bench with us. It didn’t stop Daryna from throwing the ball back.

Olena Petrivna opened and slammed shut a textbook.

“The sound a student makes when he wants to let you know he finished before everyone else.”

She did it again.

“And the one I want to be able to find annoying.”

Nina imitated the washing machine from her old apartment. She rolled her arms in front of her and made a rumble that got faster and faster. When it hit the spin cycle, her voice went so high that Anastasiya jumped, then clapped her hands together.

Mykola did the engine of the bus that used to pass his house at ten after six. Uncle Serhiy added the driver's whistle. Two women imitated a Saturday market, one shouting the price of apples, the other protesting that at that price, the apples should at least know how to sing.

Ihor had repaired a bicycle bell. He rang it once.

The little *ding* flew across the yard.

I saw our street again before the metal barriers. A boy coming down the hill too fast and ringing so everyone would get out of the way. Mama complaining from the sidewalk. Papa saying brakes would be more useful. Maksym cheering the boy on.

"Again," I asked.

Ihor rang the bell three times.

Vira refused to take part until Solomiya brought her the bear book.

"He won't fall asleep without a song," she said.

"That bear survived soup that was too salty. He'll survive insomnia."

Solomiya set the book open on her knees.

Vira looked at us as if we had set a very mediocre trap. Then she started a lullaby.

I knew the tune. Mama used to sing it sometimes while she tidied the landing books. She made up half the words when she couldn't remember the real ones. Vira knew every verse. Her voice wasn't beautiful the way singers on TV were beautiful. It was low, worn in some places, solid in others. A voice made for crossing a dark bedroom without turning on the light.

Before the end, Nina joined in. Then Olena Petrivna. Ihor sang too low for anyone to prove he was getting it wrong.

I looked at the red light on the recorder.

Vira saw it too.

She kept going.

When the song ended, I held out the notebook, open to the Register of the Living.

“Permission still pending,” I reminded her.

She took the pencil.

After her name, she wrote: *Can’t sing as well as people claim. Keeps sugar too long. Raised a boy who ties blankets badly.*

Ihor protested.

Vira added: *Refuses to correct the last sentence.*

Then it was Anastasiya’s turn. Nina gave her a wooden spoon and set a small pot in front of her.

“Gently,” I said.

My sister hit it with every bit of strength in her arm.



The noise sent two birds flying off the roof.

Anastasiya froze, impressed by her own power. Then she did it again. She didn't follow any known rhythm. Every whack came just when we thought she was done.

We laughed before she did.

So she laughed too, and banged faster.

For one minute, the village wasn't waiting for the convoy. It wasn't counting its supplies or listening to the sky. It made enough noise to be its own place.

The convoy was late.

At noon, no vehicles had appeared on the road. A radio message said a bridge had to be checked. The arrival was pushed back to the end of the day, maybe to the next morning.

Nobody took the benches down.

Late in the day, I went down into the cellar with the notebook and the recorder. The festival had given me an idea I didn't know how to name yet. Until then, I'd believed that bearing witness meant showing what the war had broken. But if someone only saw our open walls, our blankets, and our lists, they might think we had always lived like this.

I opened the page *To Those in Charge* again.

The unfinished sentence was waiting for me:

*When you decide how long a war can last, how many roads
can close, and how many children can wait...*

I crossed out the whole line.

It still sounded like an adult behind a podium.

I started again lower down.

SECOND TRY, FOR THOSE IN CHARGE
<i>Here's what we need: a road where ambulances can get through, medicine that arrives before the fever does, a school whose ceiling stays where it belongs, and news that contains something besides the word transferred.</i>
<i>We need you to ask before you show our faces. A child doesn't become public because her house is broken.</i>
<i>We need grownups to stop calling us brave when what they mean is used to it.</i>
<i>I want my sister to learn the word school before the word...</i>

The alert started.

This time, the siren didn't come from the village. Ihor's portable radio let out three short notes. He appeared on the stairs.

"Everybody downstairs. Now."

I put the pencil down in the middle of the sentence. In the yard, benches scraped the ground. Footsteps were already coming down toward us. Vira picked up Anastasiya. Olena Petrivna was counting the children.

I wanted to put the notebook in my bag.

Pavlo shouted that Daryna was still outside.

I left the notebook open on the table and ran for the stairs.

Above us, a hurried foot knocked Anastasiya's pot, left behind in the yard. It began rolling across the concrete.

It spun around, slower and slower.

Then another sound began.

CHAPTER TWENTY-ONE

Under the Bricks

The night of June 5 to 6



SOUND KEPT

three knocks under what had collapsed.

Daryna was on her knees behind the last bench. She was searching for something in the dust. The alert kept repeating its three notes. Over the houses, a rumble was coming in waves.

“Daryna!”

She raised her hand. She was holding the deflated ball.

“It’s Mykhailo’s.”

I wanted to tell her a ball didn’t count. Then I thought of the red notebook, lying open on the table downstairs.

“Grab it and run.”

We made it to the stairs. Daryna hugged the ball to her. I held on to the back of her coat so I wouldn’t lose her. When we came into the cellar, Olena Petrivna shouted her name and made a mark on her list.

“Everyone’s here,” she announced.

Vira had put Anastasiya in her basket by the inner wall. She was pulling the littlest kids away from the shelves. Ihor and Mykola were closing the metal door at the top of the stairs. Nina was handing out blankets, as if the cold were a problem she refused to give up on in the middle of all the others.

I went over to the notebook.

The pencil was still lying on the unfinished sentence. I took it off before I closed the cover. A first impact made the dust tremble between the beams.

The lights flickered.

Somebody started to pray. Somebody else asked them to pray more quietly so we could hear the instructions. Anastasiya was crying. I sat down beside her basket and slid a hand onto her stomach.

“I’m here,” I told her.

The second impact put the lights out.

After that, my memories don’t line up in order anymore.

A huge noise.

The floor rising under my knees.

Daryna’s blanket against my face.

Vira shouting a single word:

“Push!”

Then the cellar filled up with matter. Dust, plaster, little pieces of wood, and a darkness so thick it seemed to fall along with them.

I couldn’t hear Anastasiya anymore.

I called her. My mouth was full of dust. No real sound came out.

A flashlight came back on somewhere on the floor. Its beam turned without finding a hand. It lit up a shoe, a cracked wall, white specks floating slowly down.

Anastasiya's basket wasn't by the wall anymore.

It had rolled under the table. A brick had shattered in the spot where it had been a few seconds before.

My sister finally cried. I have never been so grateful for a scream.

I crawled to her. The basket was lying on its side, but the blanket and the wooden rim had held her in. I pulled her out. My fingers checked her head, her face, her arms. She was howling and pushing my hands away.

"Keep going," I whispered. "You can even be unbearable."

Mama's shawl was caught on the side of the basket. I pulled it free, tied it around my chest, and settled Anastasiya against me. My hands knew the way without waiting for my thoughts.

"Answer when I call you!" Olena Petrivna was shouting.

She was reading her list. Voices came out of the dark, some close, others muffled by blankets or fear.

Pavlo didn't answer.

I found him sitting under the fallen blackboard. He wasn't trapped. He was hugging his knees and staring at the ceiling.

"Get up."

He didn't move.

I saw my notebook a few steps away. It had slid off the table. A board lay across its cover, but I could still reach it.

Another tremor went through the wall.

I reached out my hand.

Pavlo grabbed my sleeve.

"I can't feel my legs."

"They're right there. I can see them."

"They won't listen to me."

The notebook was close enough for me to make out the tape fixing its spine. I thought of Mama's pages, the three messages, the letter taped back together, the laugh I had written down in words.

Then a stone fell between the notebook and me.

I took Pavlo's hand.

"We'll give your legs a simpler order. Up."

He shook his head.

"Then start with one knee."

We stood up together. His legs worked badly, but they worked. He hung on to my belt. Anastasiya was screaming under my chin.

"The main way out is blocked!" Mykola called.

Ihor had found the old storeroom behind the kitchen. A small door opened onto a service staircase that was half full of rubble. He and Uncle Serhiy moved what they could. The adults formed a line. A stone passed from hand to hand, then another.

I didn't save the cellar.

I didn't lift a single beam.

I led Pavlo and Solomiya to the door. I kept saying their names. I stopped Daryna from going back for the ball when she dropped it. I held the flashlight while Nina got over a broken step.

We moved forward bent over, one person at a time.



Outside, the night was orange behind the houses. A shed was burning on the other side of the square. People were calling out. Others were counting. Between two distant rumbles, the sky had gone back to a calm that felt obscene.

Olena Petrivna started her list over from the beginning.

“Daryna?”

“Here.”

“Pavlo?”

He raised a hand without speaking.

“Solomiya? Nina? Mykola? Serhiy?”

The answers came.

“Vira?”

Nobody answered.

I looked around. Ihor was standing near the stairs, his face covered in a dust that turned his eyebrows white.

“She was behind the basket,” I said.

He took a step toward the entrance.

Mykola held him back.

“The ceiling is still moving.”

“That’s my grandmother.”

“And if you go in now, they’ll have to look for two people.”

Ihor tried to pull his arm free. Uncle Serhiy stepped in front of him. None of them were shouting. That made it worse.

I went up to the opening. Dust was drifting out of the stairwell like slow breathing.

“Vira!”

Nothing.

“Baba Vira!”

A piece of wall fell inside. Everyone jumped back except me. Mykola grabbed my arm and pulled me back. I held Anastasiya close.

"Listen before you call," Ihor said.

His voice was shaking.

We went silent.

The fire crackled on the square. A child was crying near the well. The team's radio was spitting out words too fast to follow. Anastasiya had stopped screaming and was breathing against my chest in short warm puffs.

Then I heard:

| knock.

A pause.

| knock. Knock.

Three knocks.

"She's alive!"

Ihor dropped to his knees in front of a metal pipe that came out of the wall by the stairs. He hit it three times with a stone.

The answer came back fainter.

Three knocks, then two.

"What does that mean?" Mykola asked.

"Nothing," said Ihor. "She's hitting wherever she can."

He put his ear to the pipe and moved his hand along the metal. The village's volunteer rescuers arrived with props, helmets, and a stronger flashlight. Ihor showed them where the sound was coming from. They told everyone to be quiet, knocked in several places, and waited for each answer.

The knocks weren't a plan. They didn't say how deep she was or what was holding her down. But they narrowed down where to search.

I answered from outside.

Three knocks.

I'm here.

Every time, a signal came back.

After a time I couldn't count, a voice shouted from the opening:

"We can see her!"

The rescuers put up a prop. They took the pieces out one by one. Nobody let us get close. I counted the stones they set aside until I lost track.

When they finally brought Vira out, she was strapped to a board. A blanket covered her up to her shoulders. There was a cut on her face and her leg wasn't moving, but her eyes were open.

Ihor leaned over her.

"Baba?"

"You're shouting," she murmured.

"I'm not shouting."

"Then my ears are broken. Add them to the list."

He lowered his forehead against her hand.

I wanted to ask her why she had pushed the basket. I wanted to blame her for staying. None of those words could get through my throat.

Vira turned her eyes to the shawl.

"The baby?"

I pulled the cloth back a little. Anastasiya showed her dusty forehead and let out an annoyed cry.

"All in one piece," I answered.

Vira closed her eyes.

"Then stop looking at me like I'm already a sad story."

The rescuers carried her over near the well. A nurse from the village checked her breathing and splinted her leg with whatever she had. She called for a medical evacuation over the radio.

An hour later, the head of the rescue team let Ihor go into the stabilized part of the cellar for a few minutes. He came back with a can of formula, Vira's medical bag, and my notebook.

The red cover had turned gray. One corner had gone black near the spine. Several pages were crumpled, but the tape still held.

"It was under the board," said Ihor.

I didn't reach for it right away.

Pavlo was sitting next to me, wrapped in a blanket. His eyes followed the notebook.

"You left it," he said.

I thought he was accusing me.

"Yes."

"To get me."

"Yes."

He looked down at his shoes.

"My record on one foot was fake."

"I know."

"Are you going to cross it out?"

I finally took the notebook back.

"Never."

The cover left dust on my palms. I thought about how the notebook held our memory, but it didn't have lungs, or legs, or fear in the dark.

That night, I had chosen a living hand.

The notebook had come back anyway.

CHAPTER TWENTY-TWO

Help Vira First

June 6, at dawn



SOUND KEPT

the click of a camera switching off.

The convoy arrived a night late and a few minutes right on time.

We saw its headlights on the road just as the sky was starting to go pale. Three white vehicles slowed down in front of the rubble. The first had a medical symbol on it. The second was carrying water and equipment. The third had antennas on its roof and words printed on its door.

PASSERELLE MONDE

I had to read it twice. I didn't even know what language those words were written in, but I hadn't slept, and back then a lot of things seemed out of place.

The doors opened.

Medics went straight to Vira. Other people split up between the injured, the building, and the water point. They didn't ask who deserved help the most. They asked short questions, wrote down the answers, and started with what they could do.

A woman in a dark blue jacket got out of the third vehicle. She had her hair tied back and a small notebook in her pocket. A man followed her with a camera on his shoulder. Another woman, younger, had headphones around her neck.

The camera turned toward the cellar that had caved in.
Then toward me.

I was standing next to Vira with Anastasiya tied under the shawl. My jacket was torn at the elbow. The blackened notebook was pressed against my chest. I saw my tiny reflection in the lens: a pale smudge, hair gray with dust, two eyes open too wide.

The man lifted the camera.

The woman in blue lifted her hand faster.

"Not yet," she said.

The young woman with the headphones spoke to us in our language.

"My name is Svitlana. I translate for the team. This is Aïcha Mbala, a journalist. She's asking if you'll agree to talk to us. The camera isn't recording."

I looked at the light. It was off.

Aïcha stayed several steps away. She didn't have the sad smile some adults put on in front of hurt children.

Svitlana translated her question.

"Do you want to tell us what happened?"

Next to me, a medic was cutting the sleeve of Vira's coat so he could put a cuff around her arm. Another was getting the stretcher ready. Vira was clenching her teeth without complaining, which meant she was in a lot of pain.

"Help Vira first," I answered.



Svitlana translated.

Aïcha looked at the stretcher, then at her team. She said a few quick words. The man lowered the camera. She switched it off in front of me. The little click was almost too quiet to hear under all the radios and engines.

I heard it anyway.

Aïcha called over the convoy's head doctor. She didn't pretend she knew how to treat Vira. She cleared the way, moved her team back, and asked for a second vehicle to be

made ready for the evacuation. When a crate was blocking the stretcher's path, she helped Nina drag it aside.

While the doctors worked, nobody mentioned an interview to me again.

Vira was going to be taken to a center where they could examine her leg and also check her chest. The convoy doctor used careful words. *Probable fracture. Breathing stable. Needs monitoring.* I was grateful for every one of them, because each one described what he knew without filling in the rest.

"I'm going with her," Ihor said.

"So are we," I answered.

The doctor looked at Anastasiya.

"The baby has to be examined before we leave. And so do you."

"She's fine."

Vira opened her eyes on the stretcher.

"Katya."

"What?"

"If you argue with every doctor, we'll get there next winter."

I let them lead me to a tent set up in the yard. A nurse listened to Anastasiya's breathing, checked her pupils, and ran her hands gently along her arms. My sister protested every move, then tried to steal the stethoscope.

"Encouraging response," said the nurse.

She cleaned the cut on my elbow. I hadn't noticed it was bleeding.

"Did you pass out?"

"No."

“Nausea? Dizziness?”

“Only when I think.”

She waited.

“That was a joke,” I added.

“I like to check the jokes too.”

She had me follow her finger with my eyes and gave me some water.

Through the opening of the tent, I could see the journalists. They were filming the building from the road, without showing the people being treated. Aïcha was talking with Mykola. Every time he pointed someone out, she stopped before she went closer.

She hadn't obeyed me because I was impressive. My hair was full of plaster and one of my sleeves was ripped off. She had obeyed me because I said no.

That difference mattered.

When the exam was over, Svitlana brought me a cup of tea. She wasn't wearing her headphones anymore.

“Aïcha would like to come back later without the camera,” she said. “Only if you want her to.”

“Why?”

“To find out what you're willing to tell. And what you're not.”

I looked at my notebook. The dust had worked its way under the tape, between the pages, all the way into the letters. I could clean it. I couldn't pretend that nobody beyond Lypove needed to know the names inside it.

I wanted people to learn those names. I didn't want to give them the right to take everything.

“No camera,” I said again.

“No camera.”

“And not while they’re taking care of Vira.”

“I’ll tell her.”

Svitlana stood up.

“Wait.”

She turned around.

“Passerelle Monde, what is that?”

“A news outlet for audiences who speak French, especially in Africa and in the diaspora. They also cover what’s happening here, because wars start to feel far away very fast to people who aren’t living them.”

“And if I talk, how many people will watch?”

“We can’t know that.”

It was an honest answer, and not a very comforting one.

“Okay,” I said. “Later.”

Near the exit, Aïcha caught my eye. She didn’t come closer. She only laid two fingers on her notebook, like a silent question.

I nodded once.

The camera stayed on the ground.

CHAPTER TWENTY-THREE

The Camera Switched Off

June 6, in the afternoon



SOUND KEPT

a question asked before the red button.

Aïcha came back while Vira was asleep. She had taken off her reporting jacket. Without the logo, the mic, and the man with the camera, she seemed smaller than she had that morning. Svitlana walked beside her with two notebooks and no headphones.

“May we sit down?” Aïcha asked, through her.

We were in the medical tent. Vira was lying on a cot behind a curtain. The medics had splinted her leg, clipped a sensor to her finger, and kept checking her breathing. Her evacuation was scheduled for the next morning, as soon as the road was judged passable.

Anastasiya was asleep on my lap. I had cleaned her face, but a gray line was still stuck in the fold of her ear.

“Here,” I answered. “I’m not leaving Vira.”

Aïcha chose two crates turned upside down. Before she sat, she showed me her empty hands.

“No camera. No recorder,” Svitlana translated. “Only notes, if you agree.”

“Can I ask you not to write something down?”

“Yes.”

“Even after I’ve said it?”

Aïcha answered directly, then waited for the translation.

“Yes. As long as we’re in this preparation conversation. If we record tomorrow, we’ll decide beforehand what’s meant to be public. You can also stop in the middle.”

She set her closed notebook on her knee.

“What do you want to protect?”

I was expecting *What happened?* or *How do you feel?* The question she had picked was harder.

I looked at Anastasiya.

“Her face. You can say her name, but not show her face. I don’t want strangers recognizing her for the rest of her life as the baby pulled out of the rubble.”

Svitlana translated carefully. Aïcha wrote down one sentence.

“We can keep her out of the frame and not use any footage from this morning where she might appear.”

“You filmed this morning?”

“The building, after you said no. Not you. The team will check every shot.”

“I want to see it.”

“You’ll see it.”

I kept going.

"Not the exact location of the cellar. Not the road they use for evacuations. Ihor says the relays can give away where we are too."

"We'll ask the head of the convoy what shouldn't be shown."

"And I don't want you to say I'm Anastasiya's mother."

Aïcha looked up from her notebook.

"What are you to her?"

"Her sister."

"That's the word we'll use."

"People say sometimes that I've become her mother. They think it's beautiful."

I could already feel the anger rising, even though nobody in the tent had said that sentence.

"I give her bottles. I wake up when she cries. I know how her mouth moves right before she sneezes. But I'm her sister. Our mother is dead. If you give me her place because I took care of the baby, you make her disappear a second time. And you act as if I chose to be a grownup."

Svitlana stopped before translating. She asked me to repeat the last sentence, then carried it over into Aïcha's language.

Aïcha put down her pen.

"Can that answer be in the report?"

I thought about it.

"Yes. All of it. Not just the part about knowing how she sneezes."

"All of it," she confirmed.

The curtain moved. Vira was awake.

“And write that her sister occasionally agrees to sleep,” she said.

Svitlana leaned toward me.

“Should I translate that?”

“Absolutely not.”

Vira clicked her tongue.

“Censorship.”

Aïcha hadn’t understood the words, but she had understood the tone. She smiled.

We talked about the notebook. I showed her the cover without handing it over. She asked who had written the pages. I explained about the children’s pages, the Register of the Living, and the permission everyone could take back.

“We won’t film any page without the agreement of the person it’s about, or of the adult responsible for them when that’s needed,” said Aïcha.

“The child has to agree too.”

“Both.”

“What if an adult says yes and the child says no?”

“Then it’s no, for our report.”

I opened the register to Daryna’s page.

“Yesterday she agreed to the sound, not her name. For this page, somebody will have to ask her again.”

“Agreed.”

“And the mother who smelled like apples stays without a name.”

“Agreed.”

“You say agreed a lot.”

“Part of my job is knowing what I don’t have the right to take.”

I wasn't sure yet that I trusted her. But I was starting to believe she knew the difference between asking and waiting for someone to give in.

Aïcha explained what a report could turn into. My words would be translated. Some answers would be shortened. A sequence several minutes long might end up as one. Images would be shown in several countries, then picked up elsewhere without her being able to control all of it.

"I can have you check the translation of the parts where you speak," she said. "I can show you the images we're planning to use and take out the ones we agreed to protect. I can't promise you nobody will make a bad comment or copy a clip once it airs."

"So even you don't control everything."

"No. That's why you have to know before you say yes."

That answer didn't make the camera safe. At least I could see more clearly how far my yes went.

I took the phone and the recorder out of my bag. The first file was from September 2. I had named the recordings whenever the batteries and my patience allowed it.

01_MISSING_BELL

I pressed play.

You could hear the flag against the pole, a vehicle far away, and my sleeve rubbing the mic. Denys breathing through his nose. The bell not ringing.

Aïcha listened to the whole minute.

"Almost nothing happens," said Svitlana, after translating her comment.

"That's what happened," I answered.

The second sound I picked was Anastasiya's laugh. The recording started with our pathetic imitations, then the wooden bird falling. The laugh came at the end, short and surprised.

Vira opened her eyes behind the curtain.

"Play it again," she said.

I played it again.

Then we listened to the festival from the day before: the wet ball, the slammed textbook, Nina's washing machine, the bicycle bell, the lullaby, and the pot getting beaten without mercy.

Aïcha had stopped taking notes.

"If we do this report," she said, "it won't start with the rubble."

"With what, then?"

She pointed at the recorder.

"With the school that didn't ring. And then with what you want to hear come back."

I pictured a person sitting very far away, in a city where the windows weren't covered with tape. They would hear one nearly empty minute. They could change the channel before it ended.

Or they could wait for the bell with us.

"I don't want people to think we started out under the bricks," I said. "We had a school before. Mama had a library. Ihor was already fixing things badly."

From the other side of the curtain, Vira protested.

"He still fixes them badly."

This time, I let Svitlana translate.

Aïcha laughed.

She picked up her notebook again.

“Will you agree to an interview tomorrow morning, after you’ve slept?”

I looked at the camera sitting outside, its light still off. Then at the notebook, one blackened corner sticking out of my bag.

“Yes, with conditions.”

“We’ll write them down together before we start.”

“And if I change my mind?”

“You say stop.”

“Even in the middle of an important sentence?”

“Especially then.”

She asked if she could write down that I agreed. I said yes.

This time, my yes had conditions.

WHAT CAN LEAVE THE NOTEBOOK
<i>The minute without a bell: yes.</i>
<i>Anastasiya’s laugh: yes, without her face.</i>
<i>The festival of sounds: yes, for the people who confirm tomorrow.</i>
<i>The letter to God: no.</i>
<i>Mama’s pages: no.</i>
<i>The Register of the Living: only the lines that have been allowed, one by one.</i>
<i>The exact location of the shelter: no.</i>
<i>The word mother for me: no.</i>
<i>The word sister: yes.</i>
<i>The right to say stop: yes, even after saying yes.</i>

CHAPTER TWENTY-FOUR

We Were Here

June 7



SOUND SENT

my voice, after I chose the words.

The first thing the camera recorded was my cough. I had swallowed the last sip of water the wrong way. Aïcha waited without touching her mic. The man behind the camera looked at his shoes. Svitlana handed me a tissue.

“We can start over,” said Aïcha.

“Delete that.”

“It’s already done.”

The camera was set up on a tripod in the shade of the vehicle. In the frame, you could see a chair, my hands, and the notebook resting on my knees. Anastasiya stayed out of the shot with Nina. She was chewing on the wing of the wooden bird. I could hear her little noises, which kept me from believing I was talking alone to a black eye.

Before the recording, we had gone over the conditions again. Aïcha had written them in both languages. Svitlana had translated every line one way, then the other. Daryna had allowed the description of Mykhailo, but not her own face. Pavlo wanted his disputed record mentioned. The apple boy had kept his mother anonymous. Vira had allowed her lullaby to be used, on the condition that nobody present her as a professional singer.

“Ready?” Aïcha asked.

“No.”

“We’ll wait.”

I looked at the road. The medical vehicle was supposed to leave before the heat of noon. Vira was already inside. Her window was open, and her hand was resting on the edge. Ihor was checking the bags for the fourth time.

Olena Petrivna stood behind the camera with Solomiya and Pavlo. Mykola was talking to the driver. The people from the next village were waiting by the second truck. Nobody was pretending my interview would stop what had destroyed the cellar.

But the notebook could leave Lypove without being carried off by an explosion.

I put my feet flat on the ground.

“Now.”

A little red light came on.

Aïcha started with a simple question.

“What’s your name?”

“Kateryna Kovalchuk. Everybody calls me Katya. I’m fourteen.”

“Who is Anastasiya?”

“My little sister.”

“What’s that on your knees?”

I looked down.

“A notebook I bought for Ukrainian class. At first, I wrote in it for my father and my brothers, because they were gone. After that, I wrote so I wouldn’t lose what the days kept making disappear. Now other people have their pages in it.”

“Why do you want to share it?”

The answer I’d prepared left my head.

I looked at Aïcha instead of the camera.

“I don’t know if I want to share it.”

The man behind the camera didn’t move.

“Do you want to stop?” Aïcha asked.

I thought of Daryna bent over the word *missing*. Of Bohdan asking for three knocks. Of Vira under the stones. Of Mama promising a reminder letter from the balcony.

“No. I just want that sentence to stay in too. I’m not sure. I’m doing it anyway, because silence is already deciding for us.”

Aïcha waited for Svitlana to translate.

“Which page did you choose to read?”

I opened the notebook. The text was covered with words that had been crossed out. A sentence climbed up the margin. Two words had been replaced by another one written so small I had to bring the page closer.

“It’s called *To Those in Charge*. I started it several times.”

My voice shook from the first line. I didn’t hide it.

	TO THOSE IN CHARGE
	You call us brave. I know you mean to be kind, but I don't want to be brave in that way.
	I want to be late for school. I want to forget my homework and make up a bad excuse. I want to fight with my brothers because they took my charger. I want my sister to learn the word school before the word shelter.
	Here's what we need: roads where ambulances can get through, medicine that arrives before the fever does, and classrooms where the ceiling stays above the students. We also need you to ask before you take our faces. A destroyed house doesn't destroy our right to say no.
	Don't only count our dead. Count the notebooks left empty, the birthdays that got interrupted, the jobs we wanted to learn, and the bad jokes nobody recorded.
	In our register, Mykhailo hates beets and shuts his eyes when the ball comes. A woman smelled like real apples and always sang the last word too soon. Paulo can't stand on one foot as long as he claims. Vira keeps sugar for months and sings better than she admits.
	Anastasiya doesn't know your borders or your speeches. She knows the warmth of a shawl, Vira's voice, and the hands of everyone who held her when mine were shaking.
	I'm not asking you to cry over my notebook. I'm asking you to keep another child from starting theirs this way.
	We had names before the pictures. We had lives before the ruins.
	We were here.

The red light burned in my eyes.

Nobody spoke right away.

Anastasiya dropped the bird. The wood hit the step of the vehicle. She let out a cry demanding that someone give it back.

I turned toward the sound.

"It's okay," I said. "You can keep that too."

Aïcha asked one last question.

"What do you want to hear when this war is over?"

I could have said the bell, Mama's laugh, or Papa's key in the door. All those answers were true.

"Somebody complaining that there's nothing to talk about," I said.

Aïcha smiled.

"Stop," I added.

The light went out.

The team showed me the footage from the day before. My face wasn't in it. Neither was Anastasiya's. You could see the wall that had split open, the rescuers' hands, buckets of water, and the blackened notebook, filmed from too far away to read a single page.

Then Svitlana read me back the translation of my answers. I asked for changes in two places. The word they'd chosen for *shelter* was too close to *home*. And the sentence about my mother had lost the idea that she was being made to disappear a second time. Both got fixed.

Aïcha didn't ask me for the notebook right away.

I was the one who took it out of my bag.

"You can make a copy and translate the pages I've marked," I said. "Not the others."

"The original will be returned to you."

"When?"

"As soon as possible after it's scanned. I'll write down where it will be kept and the name of the person responsible for it."

Together, we numbered every sheet that had writing on it. The pages I allowed got a little pencil circle in the margin. The forbidden pages got no mark. I added a separate list for the ones whose permission still had to be confirmed.

Aïcha wrote a receipt in both languages. It described the red notebook, its blackened corner, the tape on its spine, and the date she was taking it. She signed. I signed too. From the vehicle, Vira insisted that Ihor take a picture of the document with the convoy's camera.

"If she loses the notebook, I'll track her down," she announced.

Svitlana translated without my asking.

Aïcha put a hand on her heart.

"Consider me warned."

When I held the notebook out to her, my fingers wouldn't let go.

For one second, we were both holding it.

"You can still say no," she reminded me.

I didn't need her to encourage me to be brave. I needed her to leave the door open.

I let go.

"Make a copy. Then give it back to me."

"I promise."

She put the notebook in a waterproof pouch, right in front of me.

Olena Petrivna was waiting for me by the medical vehicle. She was holding a thin green notebook with a checkered cover.



"It's from the school's supply closet," she said. "It doesn't have many pages."

"Neither did the red one, at the start."

She gave it to me.

On the first page, someone had printed: *Name. Class. Subject.*

I wrote:

| *Kateryna Kovalchuk.*

At the line for *Class*, I hesitated. I didn't know what school we'd find, or where the convoy would take us after the care center.

I left the space empty.

At *Subject*, I wrote: *What comes next.*

Ihor helped me climb in. Vira was lying on the stretcher fastened to the floor. Anastasiya settled against me under the shawl, the wooden bird between us. The engine coughed twice before it started.

Through the window, I saw Aïcha by her vehicle. The waterproof pouch was resting against her chest.

My first notebook was leaving in one direction.

The new one was leaving with me.

I opened it on my knees.

The blank page didn't demand any promises.

It was only waiting for us to get somewhere.

EPILOGUE

The Bell and the Laugh

September 1



SOUND FOUND AGAIN

the eight o'clock bell.

On the first day of school, I put on my uniform even though the skirt was too short.

The reception center had given it to me when we arrived, in June. It fit me then. Over the summer, my legs had decided to grow without asking whether we had anything to replace my clothes with. Vira undid the hem with the tip of her little scissors and won almost two centimeters.

“Don’t breathe too hard,” she said. “We’re out of spare fabric.”

She was standing in front of me with her cane. Her leg had healed enough for her to walk, not enough for her to admit she needed help. The rehab center had taught her exercises she criticized every morning before doing them exactly right.

We were living in an old boarding school in the west of the country. Two rooms, a shared kitchen, hot water on some days. No ceiling shook when trucks drove by on the road. For the first few weeks, I looked up anyway.

I had turned fifteen in August.

Nina, who had joined us in July and was living at the end of the hall, found a handful of flour, and Vira found a real egg. The cake sank in the middle, just like the first one. Ihor stuck fifteen candles in it so close together that the top melted. We laughed before we ate the parts that weren't burned.

Ihor was taking classes at a vocational school and working afternoons in a repair shop set up behind the train station. He fixed radios, lamps, and phones for displaced families. He still left one screw over after every repair. Vira kept them in a jar as evidence for a future trial.

Aïcha had sent back the red notebook.

It came in a new pouch, along with a digital copy of the authorized pages, the translation of the pages that were broadcast, and a short letter. The report had started with the minute in front of the closed school. After that you heard Anastasiya's laugh, Ihor's bicycle bell, and Vira's song. The pictures of the ruins came later.

People had written to the news outlet. Some offered help. Others told about their own closed school, their own brother with no address, their own object carried off in a bag. Several organizations had contacted the center where we were staying. Some of the supplies that came with the convoys were from those groups; others had already been on their way before the broadcast.

The report had brought messages and a few crates. It hadn't stopped the war.

Maksym had sent a voice note from his care center. His voice was weak, but his first sentence was about the can opener.

"I request that the official history state that I won the second round."

He was doing rehab. We didn't know yet when we'd be able to see him.

Bohdan called whenever the relays and his moving around allowed it. Sometimes the connection lasted one minute, sometimes long enough for him to argue with Ihor about a battery. He always ended with three knocks.

About Papa, no certain news had come.

His name was still on the search lists. I hadn't replaced *missing* with an easier word. I hadn't let that word swallow all the other lines either.

The red notebook lived in a box under my bed now. I could open it. I could also go a whole day without opening it.

That morning, the green notebook was in my schoolbag.

Anastasiya was crawling across the middle of the room at an alarming speed. At nine months, she knew exactly which things we didn't want her to have. She went around the wooden bird, ignored a spoon, and dove toward my open schoolbag.

"No," I said.

She sped up.

I lifted the bag before she could reach the zipper. She sat down, outraged, then lifted her arms up to me.

"Ka-ya," she said.

I froze.

"What?"

"Ka-ya."

The word wasn't perfect. It could have been a noise, a coincidence, or the beginning of several other words. I took it anyway.

I sat down on the floor and held her tight. Tears ran onto her forehead. She tried to catch them with her finger.

"I'm Katya," I said again. "Your sister."

I was crying because she hadn't called me Mama.

For months, I had believed that loving her meant filling all the space that had been left empty. That morning, my name was enough. Mama got to keep hers. I got to keep mine.

Vira turned toward the window to give us some very noisy privacy.

"If you two have finished growing up, school starts in twenty minutes."

The temporary school was in an old community center. Three rooms had been split up with partitions. None of the tables matched. A map of the country covered a damp spot. At the entrance, a woman was checking names on a list.

Mine was on it.

I waited at the gate with Vira, Anastasiya, and Ihor. Other students were arriving in small groups. Some wore uniforms, others ordinary clothes. A girl with red glasses was carrying a violin. A boy was explaining that he'd forgotten his notebook while he held it under his arm.

Nobody knew yet who had lost what.

That would come later, if we chose to tell it.

The principal announced that a radio workshop would start after classes. I had proposed a project called *The Sounds That Come Back*. Every student could record a sound from their new life or keep their silence. For once, I hadn't written out the whole program before the first session.

The girl with the violin came over.

"Are you the one organizing the radio?"

"Maybe."

"I have a sound."

"The violin?"

"No. My neighbor bangs on the wall every time I practice. It's very regular."

I laughed.

At seven fifty-nine, the principal opened the gate.

I didn't take out my phone. I didn't need a screen to prove this moment was real. I picked up the green notebook and walked forward.

Behind me, Anastasiya let out a little shriek. Ihor was ringing the bicycle bell over her head. Vira was ordering him to stop getting the baby worked up. All around us, shoes were hitting the ground, chairs were already scraping in the classrooms, and someone was running because he was about to be late on the first day.

At eight o'clock, I turned around.

The bell rang. Anastasiya laughed. This time, the echo didn't come from the guns.



Words from Katya's Notebook



These notes go with the words and realities in Katya's notebook. They're simple starting points, not a summary of all of Ukraine's history or culture.

Air raid alert: a warning that a missile or drone strike may be coming. In Ukraine, it's given by sirens, on the radio, and through phone apps. Everyone goes to a shelter until the alert is over.

Baba, Babusia: loving words for "grandmother." *Babusia* is even more tender. Ihor calls his grandmother Vira that way; Katya says Baba Vira, the way people in Ukraine often do for an older neighbor they respect and love.

Evacuation order: a decision by the authorities requiring people, or certain families, to leave an area too exposed to fighting and strikes. Families with children are often the first ones affected. Volunteers and public services organize transportation and places to stay.

First day of school and the first bell: in Ukraine, the school year traditionally starts on September 1, the Day of Knowledge. A ceremony called the first bell opens the year: an older student often

carries a first grader on his shoulder while she rings a little bell. In 2024, September 1 fell on a Sunday, so classes started on Monday, September 2.

Katya, Nastia: loving short forms of Kateryna and Anastasiya. In Ukraine, almost every first name has several familiar forms. Official documents use the full name, which is why the official asks for “Kateryna Kovalchuk.”

Lypove: a village invented for this novel, in northeast Ukraine. Its name comes from *lypa*, the Ukrainian word for linden tree.

Paska: a sweet, rich Easter bread made in Ukraine, often decorated and then blessed at church. On Easter, people greet each other by saying “Christ is risen!” and answer “He is risen indeed!”

Patronymic: a name component formed from the father’s first name. Olena Petrivna is “Olena, daughter of Petro,” and Oleksiy Hryhorovych is “Oleksiy, son of Hryhoriy.” Used with the first name, the patronymic is a polite way to address an adult, a teacher for example.

Relay: an antenna that carries cell phone or radio signals. When a relay loses power or gets damaged, a whole area can be left without a signal for days.

Responsible adult: an adult designated to accompany and care for a minor when the parents cannot be there. This role alone does not establish legal guardianship. For Katya and Anastasiya, it’s Baba Vira.

School uniform: dress practices vary between schools and families. Katya wears a uniform. At the temporary school in the epilogue, some students wear one and others don’t.

Shelter: a place intended to offer protection during an air raid alert. Some basements or underground spaces are equipped for this purpose; not every underground space is a suitable shelter. In

this novel, the cellar of the school in Lypove is a shelter, a dormitory, and a classroom all at once.

Uncle, aunt: in Ukraine, children often call adults close to the family “uncle” or “aunt” (*dyadko, titka*), even when they aren’t related. Uncle Serhiy is a neighbor from Katya’s building.

A Note on the Story



Katya, her family, the journalist Aïcha Mbala, and the news outlet Passerelle Monde are made up, and so are Katya's hometown and the village of Lypove. No character in this book represents a real person.

The setting, however, is real. Since February 24, 2022, Russia has been waging a full-scale invasion of Ukraine. During the 2024 to 2025 school year, the northeastern regions near the Russian border, such as Sumy and Kharkiv, lived through shelling, missile and drone strikes, and long power outages.

On October 1, 2024, the authorities announced a decision made on September 30: the mandatory evacuation of families with children from 90 towns and villages in the Sumy district. Near the front line, many students take their classes online; others learn in shelters and basements. In Kharkiv, a first school built entirely underground opened in May 2024.

Katya's notebook covers the 2024 to 2025 school year, from the first day of school on September 2, 2024, through the summer of 2025, and then the start of the next school year. In the spring of 2025, Orthodox and Catholic Christians celebrated Easter on the same day, April 20.

MY CORNER OF THE WORLD

My Corner of the World follows four fictional young narrators in four countries on three continents. Each book can be read on its own, and they speak to each other in surprising ways.

Sokha's Diary: The Road to the Bell

The Drum and the Ball: Lamine's Journal

Ananya's Notebook: The Stolen Flame

Anastasiya's Echo: Katya's Notebook

